RNI NO.: DELENG/2005/15351

Millennium post

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PUBLISHED FROM DELHI | KOLKATA | SILIGURI | MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026 | NEW DELHI | PAGES 12 | Rs 4.00 | VOL.21, ISSUE 276



DELHI'S AIR QUALITY MARKS 83-DAY LOW P3



BJP SEEKS TO DEBUNK OPPOSITION CLAIMS ON SIR P5

'WILL TAKE EVERY POSSIBLE LEGAL ACTION' P12

US has 'deliberately become a lonelier power': Jaishankar

Says India has moved beyond advocacy, engages Russia and Ukraine for peace

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 4

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Sunday said the United States had "deliberately become a lonelier power" as its repositioning and the rise of China reshape the global order, while emerging and middle powers respond by diversifying partnerships and pursuing greater self-reliance. In this changing landscape, he said India had also moved beyond simply advocating dialogue and diplomacy on the Ukraine conflict, holding conversations with both Russia and Ukraine on the safety of Black Sea shipping, grain and energy exports and possible non-attack arrangements. "No one in the room would disagree with the fact that the landscape today is primarily marked by a radical repositioning of the United States," Jaishankar said.



PHOTO ANI

He described the US shift as "a posture of choice" and said the second major feature of the global landscape was the rise of China. China, he said, accounts for about one-third of global manufacturing and its economic capabilities are translating into political influence.

"We are looking at very sharp competition," Jaishankar said, adding that the rivalry between Washington and Beijing was affecting countries beyond the two powers. "That competition today, not limited to these two countries, has led to a weaponisation of any leverage that any country has," he said. At the same time, he said the rivalry coexisted with the "complexity of interdependence".

Jaishankar said emerging and middle powers were becoming more conscious of their own interests and seeking greater self-reliance. They were increasingly focused on diversifying and de-risking their economies, security arrangements and supply chains while developing new forms of cooperation.

"What unites the emerging and middle powers, differentiated as they may be, is a growing self-awareness of their interest," he said. "All of them, CONTINUED ON P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- US repositioning and China's rise are reshaping global order
- US-China rivalry is affecting countries beyond the two powers
- China accounts for about one-third of global manufacturing
- Emerging powers are pursuing greater self-reliance
- Countries are diversifying economies, security and supply chains
- India has moved beyond advocating Ukraine peace
- New Delhi is engaging both Russia and Ukraine

'STRIKES AT HEART OF CONSTITUTION'

SC judge: 'Whataboutery cannot justify disenfranchising millions'

Oppn says CEC 'exposed'

MPOST BUREAU
Hyderabad, October 4

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday said any process that disenfranchises millions of Indian citizens is "intrinsically arbitrary", strikes at the "very heart of the Constitution" and amounts to a "negation of the constitutional order", asserting that the Constitution does not permit two classes of citizens, those with voting rights and those without them. Speaking at the valedictory address of the 19th NALSAR-Justice BR Sawhney Memorial Moot Court Competition in Hyderabad, Justice Bhuyan said such an exercise would violate Articles 14 and 326, which guarantee equality and universal adult suffrage. "No amount of whataboutery can justify it," he said.


Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

Justice Bhuyan did not name any specific electoral exercise or authority, but his remarks came amid continuing legal and political scrutiny of the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. He said the right to vote was inseparable from citizenship and removing it would be "like taking out the soul from the body".

Referring to the constitutional framework, he said Article 325 provides for CONTINUED ON P4

SC to hear today pleas for suspension of CEC

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The Supreme Court will on Monday hear a batch of pleas seeking the suspension of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and challenging decisions allegedly taken by him without the concurrence of the other two Election Commissioners.

A bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, along with Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, will hear petitions filed by Rakesh Kumar Singh and advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi. SEE P6

Briefs

AIFF polls on December 20

KOLKATA: The All India Football Federation (AIFF) on Sunday decided to hold its much-awaited elections on December 20, bringing an end to the uncertainty over the timing of the polls to elect its new office-bearers and executive committee.

The decision was taken at the Special General Body Meeting (SGBM) of the national federation here, which was attended by members of the AIFF Executive Committee, representatives of member associations as well as officials from FIFA and the Asian Football Confederation (AFC). CONTINUED ON P4

135 years, 8.5 lakh books: SC to hear library relocation case

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court is set to hear on October 5 a suo motu case concerning the proposed relocation of Delhi's 135-year-old Central Secretariat Library (CSL), which houses more than 8.5 lakh books.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva will hear the matter titled, "In Re: 135-year-old library, 8.5 lakh books – and no room in the Central Vista plan".

The case was registered on October 3 following reports that the library had not been allotted adequate space under the Central Vista redevelopment project.

The CSL has been housed across four floors of Shastri Bhawan since 1969. Recent reports said the Ministry of Housing and CONTINUED ON P4

Central Delhi sealed as protest against CEC Kumar intensifies

AISA members claim Neha Bora picked up by police

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, October 4

The heart of the national capital transformed into a fortress on Sunday as demonstrations demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar entered their third consecutive day. Around 5,000 security personnel, including personnel from the Rapid Action Force (RAF) and other paramilitary units, lined key thoroughfares as the city witnessed clashes, detentions of political figures and allegations of sexual harassment against a senior police officer by protesting women journalists.

Despite Delhi Police denying permission for planned marches from India Gate to Jantar Mantar, large crowds gathered as part of a widening multi-city agitation. The protests intensified following an investigative report by The Indian Express, which reported that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh CONTINUED ON P4



Three women journalists allege sexual harassment by police, Crime Branch to launch probe

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The allegations of police misconduct against women journalists covering the protest at Jantar Mantar intensified on Sunday, with the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) staging a demonstration outside the Parliament Street police station and demanding registration of an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat.

Three women who identified themselves as journalists have alleged that they were manhandled and sexually harassed by police personnel during their detention while covering the October 3 protest seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

CONTINUED ON P4

GST Council may end arrest powers, raise prosecution threshold to Rs 5 crore

May clear sweeping compliance reforms; e-commerce sellers, genuine biz to get relief

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 4

The GST Council is set to consider a broad package of next-generation reforms on October 7 aimed at making tax administration simpler, reducing litigation and shifting enforcement away from coercive measures, including a proposal to remove GST officers' power to arrest and require judicial authorisation for any arrest.

The proposed enforcement changes would also raise the threshold for launching criminal prosecution from Rs 1 crore to Rs 5 crore and narrow prosecution provisions so routine disputes over classification, valuation and input tax credit do not become criminal cases. The government would retain powers to recover taxes, interest and penalties, while serious fraud and deliberate evasion could continue to be prosecuted through courts.

The wider reform package seeks to simplify GST registration and returns, speed up refunds, protect genuine buyers' input tax credit when suppliers default, and reduce low-value litigation. One proposal would bar notices where the tax demand is below Rs 10,000, covering cases that account for about 20 per cent of disputes by number but involve little revenue. SEE P10

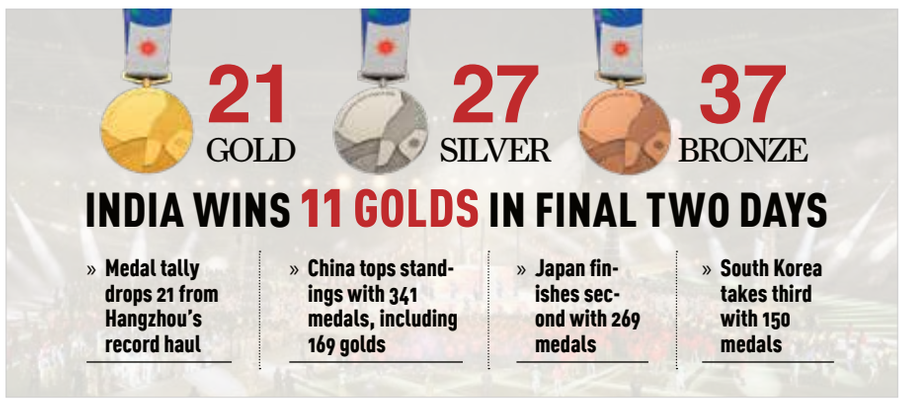
WHERE LIGHT LINGERS


A boy fishes in a wetland, in Nadia, West Bengal, on Sunday PTI

INDIA FINISHES FOURTH

From 106 to 85: India's Asiad reality check

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 4



India's sporting progress faced a reality check at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games as the country finished fourth but slipped from its record medal tally at Hangzhou. India won 85 medals, comprising 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze, 21 fewer medals and seven fewer golds than its 106-medal haul at the previous edition.

The result kept India among Asia's leading sporting nations, but also showed how difficult it will be to maintain momentum as the country targets a place among the world's top 10 sporting nations by 2036 and the top five by 2047.

China dominated the standings with 341 medals, including 169 golds. Japan finished second with 269 medals and 83 golds, while South Korea was third with 150 medals and 39 golds. India's fourth-place finish was secured only after a strong closing phase, with the country winning 11 gold medals in the final two days.

The biggest concerns came from shooting and athletics, two disciplines that had played major roles in India's success at Hangzhou.

Shooting produced 15 medals in Aichi-Nagoya, including three gold, eight silver and four bronze. This was a sharp decline from the seven gold, nine silver and six bronze medals won in Hangzhou.

India's campaign began with several missed opportunities. Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker endured a disappointing Games, while the Indian women failed to win a medal in the 10m air pistol. The men's 10m air pistol team of Kamaljeet, Aakash Bhardwaj and Kedarling Uchaganve also failed to convert expectations into medals. CONTINUED ON P4

Koel Mallick to return to Rajya Sabha three months after quitting as TMC MP

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Kolkata, October 4

Actor-turned-politician Rukmini Mallick, popularly known as Koel Mallick, is set to return to the Rajya Sabha, barely three months after resigning as a Trinamool Congress (TMC) nominee. This time, she will contest as a BJP nominee.

On Sunday, the BJP named Koel Mallick as its candidate for the October 16 Rajya Sabha bypoll to the seat she had vacated on July 16.

Mallick's candidature marks a dramatic political turnaround. The TMC nominated her to the Rajya Sabha earlier this year, and she took oath on April 6. However, she resigned on July 16, shortly after the Assembly polls, and later joined the BJP. Her brief stint in Parliament ended without her attending a single Rajya Sabha sitting.


FILE PIC

The BJP's decision has cleared the way for her to retain CONTINUED ON P4

JNUSU BEGINS INDEFINITE HUNGER STRIKE

Infra decay, administrative gridlock fuel unrest at JNU

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, October 4



Under the shadow of peeling hostel paint, malfunctioning elevators, and a growing crisis of public university funding, Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) has once again become the epicenter of a high-stakes student movement. Following an Adhikar March starting from Ganga Dhaba, the Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union (JNUSU) launched an indefinite hunger strike to challenge mounting administrative apathy and structural rot.

A Campus on Edge

The agitation highlights deep-seated grievances over crumbling infrastructure and democratic censorship.

Protesters fasting at campus locations report declining health metrics, including significant drops in body weight, fluctuating blood sugar levels, and blood pressure complications. Despite the physical toll, student representatives note that while medical teams conduct daily check-ups, university authorities have failed to initiate meaningful dialogue.

At the center of the unrest is a 13-point charter demanding urgent structural fixes. Students have pointed to non-functional elevators in hostels like Kaveri, Periyar, and Godavari, broken campus roads, inadequate library seating, and missing mess and Wi-Fi facilities in Barak Hostel.

Leaders like JNUSU President Aditi stressed the immediate need to renovate hostels, upgrade health centers, construct gender-neutral washrooms, and repair sports facilities.

HEALTH TOLL

- The agitation highlights deep-seated grievances over crumbling infrastructure and democratic censorship
- Protesters fasting at campus report declining health metrics, including significant drops in body weight, fluctuating blood sugar levels, and blood pressure complications
- Despite the physical toll, student representatives note that while medical teams conduct daily check-ups, university authorities have failed to initiate meaningful dialogue

Democracy and Dissent on Trial

Beyond bricks and mortar, the protest targets systemic policy shifts. Student leaders criticized the prolonged rustication and suspension of JNUSU office bearers, arguing that silencing elected representatives cripples the democratic mechanism. Comrade Dev Raj and AISA activist Comrade Dhananjay highlighted that shrinking public investment and continuous funding cuts systematically starve public universities, threatening access to higher education for marginalised communities.

The movement further demands the reinstatement of the JNU Entrance Examination (JNUEE), the revival of GSCASH as an autonomous redressal mechanism, and the reform of the Equal Opportunity Cell in alignment with the Rohith Act.

As the standoff continues, the student community remains resolute in defending public and accessible education.

Seeks steps on sexual-harassment complaints

Press Club condemns police action on journalists at anti-CEC protests

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4


Police personnel try to 'evict' student activists PTI

The Press Club of India on Sunday condemned the Delhi Police's alleged treatment of journalists covering protests against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar at Jantar Mantar and demanded immediate action on complaints of sexual harassment against police personnel.

A statement from the Press Club came a day after three women journalists alleged sexual harassment by police personnel while covering the protest on Saturday. The Delhi Police said it has received their complaints and transferred those to the Crime Branch for a "fair and impartial enquiry".

"The Press Club of India is shocked and dismayed at the Delhi Police's actions against and treatment of journalists during the protests at Jantar Mantar against the chief election commissioner on Friday and Saturday," the journalists' body said in the statement.

It said a woman journalist has alleged that she was "molested and groped by an ACP" and spent hours at the Parliament Street police station on Saturday night trying to get an FIR registered.

The Press Club said journalists from independent organisations and news portals have complained that despite carrying press cards and identifying themselves as mediapersons, they were subjected to aggressive police action, with some even detained along with protesters.

"Behaviour of this kind cannot be normalised in a democracy. Journalists must be allowed to work freely, without fear, and document those who gather to raise various issues," it said.

The Press Club demanded that the Delhi Police act on the woman journalist's complaint and ensure that mediapersons are able to carry out their work without facing aggression or threats.

The allegations came amid three consecutive days of protests in the national capital demanding Kumar's resignation over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll and mass deletion of voters.

On Friday, more than 700 protesters, including Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leaders Atishi and Saurabh Bharadwaj and members of student and youth organisations, were detained after they attempted to reach Jantar Mantar despite prohibitory orders. Internet services were suspended in parts of central Delhi, and entry and exit at 12 metro stations were temporarily shut as part of security arrangements.

The protesters returned to Jantar Mantar on Saturday, when around 150 people, including AISA national president Neha Bora, activist Yogendra Yadav and senior advocate Prashant Bhushan, were detained amid heavy police deployment.

The protests continued on Sunday, with student groups calling for a citizens' march from India Gate to Jantar Mantar and police stepping up security in central Delhi.

The Press Club condemned the internet shutdown around Jantar Mantar, saying it hindered journalists. Opposition parties, student groups and civil society bodies seek the CEC's resignation over SIR, while the Election Commission has rejected allegations of wrongdoing.

Man fatally stabs wife after 'argument over his affair': Cops

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

A 36-year-old man was arrested for stabbing his wife to death over an argument about his alleged extra-marital affair, police said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Pardeep, who owns a biryani stall, was apprehended at Dwaraka's Sector-20.

According to police, a PCR call regarding the stabbing near Kali Mata Mandir in JJ Colony, Palam, was received at 4.49 pm on September 27.

"The woman, identified as Sonia (30), was rushed to Indira Gandhi Hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead. During an investigation, police found that Sonia had allegedly confronted her husband over his alleged extra-marital relationship. The argument escalated, and Pardeep attacked her with a butcher's knife, causing multiple injuries to her chest and neck," a senior police officer said.

A case was registered at Palam Village police station on the statement of an eyewitness. The Crime Branch subsequently deployed technical and manual surveillance to trace Pardeep, who had been absconding since the incident.

Police arrested Pardeep in Dwarka on October 2 after receiving information about his whereabouts. He admitted involvement, while police probe his strained marriage and seek to recover the weapon.

After Saini's order, 10 held for dumping Delhi waste in Ggm

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gurugram, October 4

Gurugram Police have arrested 10 people in four cases for allegedly bringing garbage and plastic waste from Delhi for dumping in the city, officials said on Sunday.

The action followed Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini's direction on Saturday to impound vehicles transporting garbage from Delhi. Saini said Gurugram would not be allowed to become "Delhi's dumping ground".

Police also recovered seven vehicles, including canters and tractor-trolleys, allegedly used in the offences.

> GURUGRAM POLICE ALSO RECOVERED SEVEN VEHICLES, INCLUDING CANTERS AND TRACTOR-TROLLEYS, ALLEGEDLY USED IN THE OFFENCES

As part of a special drive, two cases were registered at Bajghera police station and one each at Udyog Vihar and Rajendra Park police stations. Police said teams intercepted the vehicles during checking and naka-bandi at various locations.

Preliminary investigation revealed that the accused were allegedly operating through a network connected with Delhi. The plastic was separated and segregated before being allegedly transported to other places.

Police said they were probing the network and the possible involvement of other persons and vehicle owners. Further action will be taken if their involvement is established, an officer said.

IIT-D PhD student's death: Police file FIR

New Delhi, October 4

An FIR has been registered in connection with the death of a 40-year-old PhD student of the IIT-Delhi, who was found unconscious and injured at his rented accommodation in Munirka in August, police said on Sunday.

The FIR under section 108 (abetment of suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) was lodged at the Kishangarh police station on October 4 following directions from the Supreme Court and a complaint received from the security officer of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), they said.

The man was found in an unconscious and injured condition inside his rented house in Munirka village on August 18, a senior police officer said.

The door was locked from inside and was broken open by neighbours. He was immediately taken to the AIIMS Trauma Centre by police. He remained under medical care for more than 45 days before succumbing to his injuries at the hospital on October 3, police said.

Police said the incident occurred outside IIT-Delhi campus, with the student alone; no family member or witness raised suspicion against anyone. MPOST

Air-conditioned skywalk opens between Noida Sector 52-51 stns

DIPIKA KIROLA
Noida, October 4

A 460-metre air-conditioned skywalk connecting the Sector 52 Delhi Metro station with the Sector 51 Noida Metro station was opened to commuters on Sunday, providing a covered pedestrian link between the two metro networks. Built at a cost of around Rs 36.9 crore, the facility is expected to benefit nearly 75,000 to 80,000 metro passengers. It was inaugurated by MLA Pankaj Singh.

The 6.5-metre-wide skywalk has been designed to make transfers between the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and Noida Metro Rail Corporation (NMRC) more convenient and safer. It has 10 travelators to facilitate movement, particularly for passengers carrying luggage or travelling during peak hours.

> BUILT AT A COST OF RS 36.9 CRORE, THE FACILITY IS EXPECTED TO BENEFIT NEARLY 75,000 TO 80,000 METRO PASSENGERS. IT WAS INAUGURATED BY MLA PANKAJ SINGH

Officials said the facility has five fire exits, 36 CCTV cameras and a 500 KVA diesel generator for power backup.

Noida Authority additional chief executive officer Vandana Tripathi and other senior officials, besides representatives of NMRC and DMRC, attended the inauguration.

Tripathi said the skywalk would ease pedestrian movement and provide commuters with a safer, weather-protected route between the two stations, particularly during extreme weather and busy travel hours.

Rohini court lawyers to strike today; bar police entry over 'assault' on advocate

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The Rohini Court Bar Association has called for complete abstention from judicial work at the district court complex on Monday to protest the alleged manhandling and physical assault of an advocate at a police station.

The association also said no police official from any district would be allowed to enter the court premises that day.

In a notice dated October 3, Bar president Rajiv Tehran and honorary secretary Pardeep Khatri said advocate Kamaldeep was allegedly manhandled and assaulted at Mahendra Park police station on September 29. The association said its executive committee raised the matter with senior police officers and the principal district and sessions judge, North-West district.

The DCP had assured the committee that appropriate action would be taken against the police officials concerned, it said. Bar alleges police high-handedness and intimidation, announces October 5 court work boycott in protest against the action.

'You can't turn a blind eye. Remove only what is necessary'

HC seeks DDA & DMRC response on trees damaged by Metro work

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4



The Delhi High Court has sought response of the DDA and DMRC on a plea to direct the authorities to stop damaging trees on a land where construction of an underground metro is underway in Karol Bagh area here.

The petition alleged that large-scale construction is going unabated in the area which is damaging the fully grown trees.

Justice Jasmeet Singh issued notice to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and Delhi government and asked them to file their replies to the petition.

> THE PETITION CLAIMED THAT DMRC HAS DAMAGED VARIOUS TREES WHILE CONSTRUCTING THE BOUNDARY...

"What is this? You can't turn a blind eye. Remove only what is necessary," the judge orally told the authorities.

The court listed the matter for further hearing on October 6.

Petitioner advocate Arpit Bhargava submitted that the DMRC is undertaking massive construction work on a vacant land, belonging to DDA, on Desh Bandhu Gupta Road in Karol Bagh, behind his residence where huge trees are present.

He said in the course of the construction activity, substantial quantities of iron/steel rods and other construction material are being cut/processed using mechanical equipment, resulting in generation of smoke, dust, fumes and particulate matter.

The smoke, dust and construction-generated pollutants are being emitted in close proximity to the mature trees and are visibly settling upon the foliage and surrounding soil, the plea submitted.

Besides, the petition claimed that DMRC has damaged various trees while constructing the boundary for some underground construction work and is also destroying old and large peepal trees.

The petitioner said he has submitted a complaint to the authorities informing them about illegal felling of trees and damage and destruction of large and old peepal trees behind his residence but no action has been taken till date.

Jantar Mantar protesters allege police excesses

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, October 4

Protesters detained during demonstrations at Jantar Mantar demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar have alleged physical and sexual harassment by police personnel, while the Delhi Police termed the allegations "baseless".

More than 500 protesters have been detained in Delhi so far, with some alleging they were picked up twice. Protesters said those detained were taken to different police stations and released after some time, with some allegedly being taken to locations away from Jantar Mantar.

A 23-year-old protester alleged that police personnel forcibly took mobile phones, microphones and cameras from detainees and did not record their details before releasing them. Another 25-year-old woman alleged that a male constable touched her inappropriately while she was being detained. Some protesters also alleged that they were beaten by police personnel and kept in rooms without CCTV cameras.

DCP New Delhi Sachin Sharma denied the allegations, saying police personnel had themselves been assaulted during the protests.

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Printed and Published by Jaiyendra Kumar Sharma on behalf of Front Row Media Pvt. Ltd. and printed at The Indian Express Pvt. Ltd., A-8, Sector-7, Noida-201 301 (U.P.) and published from First Floor, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002. Editor: Durbar Ganguly. Email: editor@millenniumpost.in, Tel. No. 011-47777500, Kolkata office: Room No 1,15th Floor, Chatterjee International Centre, 33A Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Kolkata 700071 West Bengal, Siliguri Office: Techno India Group Zonal Office G-212, 2nd Floor Office Block - City Centre Matigara District Darjeeling Pin - 734010 Phone- 0353- 2576321

AQI REACHES 187

Delhi's air quality marks 83-day low



OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

Delhi's air quality deteriorated to an AQI of 187 on Sunday, the highest in 83 days and in the 'moderate' category, while the maximum temperature was recorded at 36.4 degrees Celsius, 2.2 notches above normal.

The minimum temperature stood at 24.1 degrees Celsius, 1.8 notches above normal.

The air quality had last reached a higher level on July 13, when the city recorded an AQI of 246.

According to the Sameer app, 16 monitoring stations in Delhi recorded air quality in the 'poor' category, with Mundka recording the highest AQI of 273, followed by Narela at 257. As many as 26 stations saw AQIs in the 'moderate' category, while Burari was the only station where the air quality was in the 'satisfactory' category.

The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) considers an AQI between zero and 50 as 'good', 51 and 100 'satisfactory', 101 and 200 'moderate', 201 and 300 'poor', 301 and 400 'very poor', and 401 and 500 'severe'. Delhi recorded the highest maximum temperature of 37 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar, followed by 36.4 degrees at Safdarjung, 36.3 degrees at Lodi Road, 35.8 degrees at Ridge and 34.6 degrees at Palam. Safdarjung logged a minimum of 24.1 degrees Celsius, while Lodi Road recorded 23.2 degrees, Ayanagar 22.8 degrees, Palam 22.4 degrees and Ridge 21 degrees.

According to the Indian Agricultural Research Institute, a total of 203 stubble-burning incidents were recorded across Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh between September 15 and October 3.

On October 3, Punjab recorded one such incident, while Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh reported 12 and 15, respectively. Delhi recorded only one stubble-burning incident during the period, on September 19, when it reported its first such incident of the season, the data showed. Relative humidity was recorded at 51 per cent at 5.30 pm.

The IMD has forecast a clear sky in Delhi on Monday, with the maximum and minimum temperature expected to hover around 36 and 24 degrees Celsius, respectively.

HIGHLIGHTS

- The maximum temperature was recorded at 36.4 degrees Celsius, 2.2 notches above normal
- The minimum temperature stood at 24.1 degrees Celsius, 1.8 notches above normal
- The air quality had last reached a higher level on July 13, when the city recorded an AQI of 246
- According to the Sameer app, 16 monitoring stations in Delhi recorded air quality in the 'poor' category, with Mundka recording the highest AQI of 273, followed by Narela at 257

Yamuna to get a 48-km riverbed scan

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, October 4

The Delhi government is set to conduct detailed topographic and bathymetric surveys of the entire 48-km stretch of the Yamuna from Palla on the Delhi-Haryana border to Jaitpur on the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border, in a bid to build a comprehensive picture of the riverbed, identify obstructed stretches and track changes in the river's course.

The Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) department invited bids on October 1 for carrying out the two surveys. Officials said the exercise will cover not only the river channel but also embankments, spurs, drains, islands, encroachments and ghats located within 100 metres of either bank. The bathymetric survey will examine the underwater profile of the river, with cross-sections to be taken at intervals of 250 metres along the 48-km stretch. The topographic survey, meanwhile, will prepare a contour map of the river and surrounding terrain, helping identify changes in its alignment and physical features.

"Both surveys will involve the use of electronic total station machines, echo sounders and sonar systems mounted on motorboats," a senior government official said.

Bathymetric mapping essentially provides an underwater equivalent of a land survey by recording water depths and the contours of the riverbed. Officials said technologies including single-beam and multi-beam sonar, acoustic Dopplers, GPS and motion sensors would be deployed from boats. The data collected through sound velocity measurements and other sensors will subsequently be processed to generate a digital representation of the underwater surface.

The survey is expected to provide inputs for flood management by identifying clogged or altered portions of the river and understanding changes in its channel. The findings will also be used while planning proposed riverfront development and future boat navigation activities.

According to officials, the project is estimated to cost around Rs 80 lakh and the selected agency will have eight months to complete the work. The exercise comes amid the government's earlier plans to undertake dredging of the Yamuna riverbed. Last year, the Delhi government had said it would approach the National Green Tribunal seeking approval for the first such dredging exercise. The proposed intervention was aimed at restoring the river's natural flow, reducing pressure on regulator drains and improving flood resilience in low-lying areas along the Yamuna.

Dredging involves removing accumulated silt, sludge and solid waste from the riverbed and is more commonly undertaken in smaller water bodies such as canals and lakes. The proposed survey will provide detailed data on the riverbed before any such intervention is planned, officials said.

MOMENT



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, India's Kabaddi gold medalist in the Asian Games Pawan Sahrawat and others at Harewli Gaushala, in New Delhi PTI

MHI okays 382 sites for EV charging infra

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The Delhi government is set to begin the rollout of a new electric vehicle charging network after the Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI) approved 382 sites across the national capital, Power Minister Ashish Sood said on Sunday.

The Revenue Department and Delhi Transport Corporation had initially identified 456 locations for charging infrastructure, of which 382 have now received approval from the MHI. The government is preparing to float a tender for the first tranche comprising 160 to 180 sites considered ready for implementation.

Sood said all the approved locations were reassessed over the past three months following the Delhi EV Policy, notified on June 30. The exercise categorised sites according to the requirements of electric two-wheelers, three-wheelers and four-wheelers, with the aim of creating a charging network capable of meeting the capital's future demand.

The reassessment also took into account upcoming mandatory electric vehicle registration targets under the policy. From January 1, 2027, all new registrations of three-wheelers and N1 light commercial vehicles are scheduled to be electric, while the 100 per cent electric registration requirement for two-wheelers will come into effect from April 1, 2028.

The minister said the government has appointed KPMG as the Project Management Unit (PMU) and completed the comprehensive site-level assessment.

Sood said the focus of the exercise was on ensuring that charging stations are supported by adequate power availability and grid feasibility, rather than simply increasing the number of charging points.

"The success of an EV ecosystem should not be measured merely by the number of financial incentives disbursed, but by the structural transformation of charging infrastructure on the ground," he said.

He added that the government was prioritising segment-specific charging nodes so that electric vehicle users have access to suitable infrastructure across the city.

"By prioritising power availability, grid feasibility and segment-specific charging nodes, we are ensuring that when citizens transition to electric two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial vehicles, they are backed by world-class infrastructure across the capital," Sood said.

The minister said the government's work over the last quarter had focused on establishing infrastructure that could support the targets set under the Delhi EV Policy 2026.

"Delhi's primary focus over the last quarter has been to lay a sustainable, future-ready infrastructure foundation that directly aligns with the bold deadlines set under the Delhi EV Policy 2026," he said.

Sood said reliable charging infrastructure would also be critical to encouraging wider adoption of electric vehicles.

"A true EV revolution cannot rely solely on short-term financial payouts; it requires robust, reliable and segment-specific charging infrastructure that eliminates range anxiety for everyday citizens," he added.

DDA launches month-long park, sports facility clean-up

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) is conducting a month long 'Swachhata Hi Seva' campaign across its parks, green spaces, sports complexes and recreational facilities, with a focus on cleanliness, environmental improvement, public awareness and Jan Bhagidari. The campaign is being carried out under the guidance of Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who has emphasised making Delhi a clean, green and well maintained city. The campaign began on September 17 as part of 'Swachhta Hi Seva 2026'. DDA officials and staff, along with 75 RWAs, students, children, park users and people associated with public spaces, are participating in cleanliness, sanitation, plantation, awareness and public participation activities.

The campaign features three special initiatives. 'Children to the Green Learn, Care & Participate' involves children and students in cleanliness and environmental awareness activities, encouraging responsibility towards parks, trees and natural resources. 'Bin Before Overflow' focuses on regular monitoring and timely emptying of dustbins to prevent overflowing bins, littering and unhygienic conditions. Under 'Capital's Promise', attention is being given to the cleanliness and upkeep of public toilets in and around recreational areas.

The campaign also includes plantation of native tree species and environmental awareness activities focused on waste disposal, preventing littering, protecting trees and plantations, personal hygiene and responsible use of public facilities.

3 juvenile inmates escape from correctional home

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Faridabad, October 4

Three minors lodged at a juvenile correction home in connection with separate murder cases have escaped from the facility located in New Industrial Township (NIT) area here, police said Sunday.

They said the trio, all around 17 years of age, allegedly escaped Saturday night by breaking a window of an old bathroom, lowering themselves onto a nursery beneath, and fled.

Security personnel were allegedly absent during the time, while the staff had gone elsewhere. Following the incident, prevailing security arrangements at the juvenile correction home has come under scanner.

Police teams are searching for the three escapees and collecting information on their potential hideouts and contacts, while CCTV footage is being examined and raids are underway to trace the inmates, officials said.

Among the escaped minors, one is from Gurugram, another from Nuh, while the third is from Hisar district, police said. They had been placed under the department's care for rehabilitation in their respective cases.

"A complaint has been received from the juvenile correction home. Police are working to trace the trio's movements and the direction in which they fled by analysing CCTV footage.

Pink Saheli card mandatory for free bus travel by women

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The Delhi government has notified that women residents can avail free travel on DTC and cluster buses only through the 'Pink Saheli Smart Card', officials said on Sunday.

The change has been made under the Delhi Transport Corporation (Free and Concessional Passes) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

"Female passengers who are residents of Delhi can travel free in Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and cluster buses, both AC and non-AC, only with the use of Pink Saheli Smart Card (NCMC). However, they will have the option to purchase a ticket at the applicable fare for the journey," a Delhi Transport Department notification said.

Women who are not eligible for the free travel facility can also travel on DTC and cluster buses by purchasing tickets at the applicable fare, it said.

The provisions will also apply to transgender persons who are residents of Delhi, the notification added.

Launched in March this year, the NCMC-based card replaced the paper-based pink tickets earlier issued by the government after several extensions.

The Transport Department had earlier directed that the Pink Saheli Smart Card would be mandatory for availing the free travel facility from September 30.

The government will focus on creating awareness about the smart card through depot and in-bus announcements, social media, print media and other channels, officials said.

Around 19 lakh women have availed of the smart-card facility since its launch earlier this year.

Women who have not yet registered will continue to have access to the registration and card issuance process, officials said.

CYCLING, FITNESS, FUN TAKE OVER INNER CIRCLE

Raahgiri turns CP into a playground

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, October 4



Connaught Place's Inner Circle turned into a lively, people-centric space on Sunday as Raahgiri Day, held in collaboration with Sundays on Cycle, brought together Delhiites for cycling, fitness, sports, music and recreational activities.

The early-morning event temporarily freed the area from vehicular traffic, allowing children, youngsters, senior citizens and families to reclaim the streets for walking, cycling and community activities. The programme included yoga, Zumba, badminton, cricket, folk dance, puppet shows, chalk art, games and fitness sessions.

Delhi Cabinet Minister Ashish Sood, New Delhi Municipal Council chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi, Special Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Ajay Chaudhary and Raahgiri Foundation co-founder Sarika Panda Bhatt flagged off a cycle rally to mark the inauguration.

Sood said Raahgiri was not merely about individual fitness but also about the health and well-being of the city. He said cycling could help reduce air pollution while promoting physical fitness and healthier lifestyles. He added that the Delhi Government was working to develop dedicated cycling tracks and promote cleaner mobility.

Dwivedi said hosting Raahgiri at Connaught Place sent a message about cleaner and safer mobility. He said the participation of young people demonstrated the importance of collective efforts to address pollution and promote sustainable modes of transport.

Chaudhary urged Delhiites to follow traffic rules and avoid practices such as triple riding and driving on the wrong side of the road. He said controlling pollution required both collective and individual responsibility.

The event, themed "Roads are beautiful when they belong to people", also featured a live performance by Euphoria Band at Central Park. The performance drew youngsters who sang and danced along with the music.

The initiative brought together government agencies and civil society organisations, including Delhi Police, DDA, NDMC, Fit India and the Raahgiri Foundation.

The event highlighted the potential of public roads to serve as spaces for recreation, social interaction and healthier urban living beyond their conventional role as traffic corridors.

NDMC Suvidha camp receives 91 grievances

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) received 91 public grievances at its monthly Suvidha Camp held at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road on Saturday, with officials from 30 departments attending to complaints and queries. NDMC Secretary Rahul Singh led more than 100 officers and staff at the camp and reviewed the grievances with citizens. He directed heads of departments to ensure time-bound resolution of complaints and stressed the need to address recurring grievances through systemic measures.

The complaints largely related to the Personnel, Civil Engineering, Horticulture, Public Health, Enforcement, Commercial, Tax and Estate departments, according to the civic body. NDMC Chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi said the camp served as a single-window platform where residents could register grievances, seek information on civic services and interact directly with senior officials.

He said the civic body would focus on quicker disposal of complaints, identifying the root causes of recurring grievances and improving service delivery.

The Council said feedback received during the camp would be used to make changes to the existing mechanism and that a revamped "Suvidha Camp 2.0" would be launched.

Officials said matters requiring policy-level consideration were also discussed with residents, who were informed about prescribed procedures and expected timelines.

TN: Four school students found dead in lake near Chennai

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Chennai, October 4

Four school students who went missing on October 3 were found dead in the Thiruneermalai lake near Chromepet on Sunday, police said.

The deceased, all residents of Krishna Street in Lakshmipuram, were identified as Pooja, 13, Khushi, 13, K Devadarshan, 12, and Yuvanesh, 10.

The two girls were studying in Class VIII, while the boys were in Classes VII and VI, respectively, police said.

The children had gone out to play in their locality on Saturday but did not return home. After their parents and relatives searched for them and circulated their photographs in local WhatsApp groups without success, separate missing-person complaints were lodged at the Chromepet police station late Saturday night.

Around 10 am on Sunday, residents noticed four bodies floating in Thiruneermalai Periya Eri and alerted the authorities. Personnel from the Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Services (TNFRS) reached the spot and retrieved the bodies, police said.

NEARLY 9.87 LAKH PEOPLE AFFECTED BY FLOODS

Bihar: Gandak recedes, seven engineers suspended over flood response negligence

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Patna, October 4

Water level of the Gandak River in Bihar has started receding rapidly, even as the state government on Sunday suspended seven engineers and initiated departmental proceedings against another official for alleged negligence in handling the recent floods, an official statement said.

At Rewaghat in Saran, the water level of Gandak has fallen 177 cm from its record high and is now 50 cm below the danger mark, the statement issued by the Water Resources Department (WRD) on Sunday evening said.

At Lalganj in Vaishali, the level has dropped 130 cm but remains 52 cm above the danger mark. It is expected to fall below the danger mark within the next 24 hours, the release added.

There is currently no pressure on the embankments and seepage and piping problems have been resolved, the department said, adding that materials have been stocked at breach sites to protect vulnerable stretches.



Volunteers pack grains and dry ration supplies for distribution among flood-affected people at a relief material distribution centre, in Patna, Bihar PTI

The Gandak had registered unprecedented water levels following heavy rainfall in adjoining Nepal and Uttar Pradesh, with record highs reported at Devghat in Nepal and at Bagaha, Dumariaghat, Rewaghat and Lalganj in Bihar.

The department said inspections found laxity and delays in the emergency response by some engineers, including inadequate mobilisation of manpower and materials and poor coordination with locals and elected representatives.

"Seven engineers, including two executive engineers, have been suspended with immediate effect. Departmental proceedings have also been ordered against Muzaffarpur chief engineer Kumar Manoj Gupta over alleged negligence following damage to the Champaran embankment," the statement said.

Officials suspended were Saran executive engineer Santosh Kumar Prabhakar, Gopalganj executive engineer Md Sajid Iqbal, Saran assistant engineers Sunil Kumar and Vinod Kumar, Gopalganj assistant engineer Md Javed Ansari, Saran and Gopalganj junior engineers Chandrashekhar Kumar and Vikas Kumar, respectively, it added.

The department said any laxity or negligence during a disaster-related emergency would invite strict action.

Nearly 9.87 lakh people in 169 gram panchayats across 30 blocks in six Bihar districts have been affected by floods following heavy rainfall in Nepal and adjoining areas in the last week of September, officials said.

The affected districts are West Champaran, East Champaran, Gopalganj, Saran, Darbhanga and Muzaffarpur.

As part of relief measures, authorities have distributed 1,17,847 polythene sheets and 1,19,131 dry ration packets among affected people, they said.

U'khand to repeal, replace British-era irrigation law

This was the first time a state Cabinet meeting was held in Champawat

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dehradun, October 4

DHAMI SAID CABINET MEETINGS WOULD NO LONGER BE CONFINED TO DEHRADUN AND WOULD BE HELD IN DIFFERENT PLACES TO DIRECTLY PRESENT LOCAL ISSUES

The Uttarakhand Cabinet on Sunday decided to repeal the 153-year-old British-era Northern India Canal and Drainage Act, 1873, and replace it with a new law tailored to the state's unique geographical conditions, officials said.

The decision to table the Uttarakhand Irrigation and Drainage Bill, 2026, in the Assembly was made during the meeting chaired by Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami at the NHPC complex in Banbasa, Champawat district.

This was the first time a state Cabinet meeting was held in Champawat, the chief minister's Assembly constituency.

In another decision, according to a statement, the Cabinet approved amendments to the policy and standards governing the establishment of private universities.

Under the revised framework, a minimum built-up area of 2,500 square metres in hilly regions and 20,000 square metres in plain areas will be required.

It was also decided to hammer out separate evaluation criteria to ensure quality in proposals for setting up private universities.

In view of the shortage of senior residents, junior residents, and demonstrators in government medical colleges, the state Cabinet approved a revision of their payable salaries and honorariums.

Dhami said Cabinet meetings would no longer be confined to Dehradun and would be held in different places to directly present local issues, development prospects, and regional priorities to the government.

From page 1

Jaishankar

in a way, are becoming more self-reliant. It's a term, 'Atmanirbhar', very much in vogue in India as well."

On Ukraine, Jaishankar said India had become "a little bit more involved beyond advocacy" in recent months and was speaking to both sides in an effort to address immediate concerns. India has consistently called for the conflict to end through dialogue, diplomacy and negotiations.

"Our position on that conflict has been very clear, which is that we would like to see an end to this conflict," he said. India's discussions currently cover Black Sea shipping safety, grain exports, energy exports and "non-attack possibilities".

His comments came days after Russian President Vladimir Putin said Prime Minifster Narendra Modi had "good ideas" for finding a mutually acceptable solution. Ukraine Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha also said Kyiv had received proposals from India and three other countries for a possible ceasefire. Modi, during talks with Putin in Bishkek on August 31, said that "endless war must now give way to end of war".

Jaishankar said India's relationship with Russia, which dates back to the 1950s, had also evolved considerably. He said the Soviet Union had stood by India when its security and territorial integrity faced threats. Today, the relationship includes trade, investment, energy, resources, defence, nuclear cooperation and space.

He said countries no longer needed complete agreement to work together. "If you have enough touch points, that is good enough for countries to work together," he said, citing the Quad, BRICS and several connectivity initiatives as examples. Through "de-risking, diversifying and hedging", Jaishankar said, "slowly a new architecture is coming into place."

SC judge

a common electoral roll, while Article 326 establishes elections based on adult suffrage, subject to constitutionally recognised disqualifications. Though voting is not a fundamental right, he said the Supreme Court has recognised it as a constitutional right central to free and fair elections and the Basic Structure.

Justice Bhuyan also cited the Supreme Court's 1995 ruling in Lal Babu Hussain, saying a voter's name, once entered on the electoral roll, cannot be deleted without notice and an opportunity of hearing, except in the case of a dead voter.

He recalled that the Constitution-makers adopted universal adult franchise despite widespread illiteracy and inequality, calling it an "act of faith" in ordinary Indians. "One may be a billionaire, and one may be a rickshaw puller; yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal," he said.

"Article 326 cannot be tinkered with at all. No authority can do it; no court can condone it. No one is above the Constitution," Justice Bhuyan said.

The remarks drew praise from Opposition leaders. Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said Justice Bhuyan's observations showed that Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar had violated the Constitution "both in letter and spirit". Ramesh said the judge had "exposed the CEC lock, stock and barrel" and claimed Kumar had "lost all moral right to continue in office". TMC MP Mahua Moitra also praised Justice Bhuyan, saying, "It's easy for a judge to grow a spine the day he retires. It's a first when a sitting judge speaks truth to power. Kudos to Justice Bhuyan."

Central Delhi

Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised objections at least 14 times over 10 months regarding procedures related to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The Election Commission maintained that decisions were taken unanimously and that differences of opinion were normal.

Ahead of a scheduled Citizens' March organised by the All India Students' Association (AISA) at 3 pm and an Indian Youth Congress (IYC) march at 5 pm, authorities imposed extensive security restrictions in central Delhi. Multi-layered barricades blocked routes from Tolstoy Marg, Janpath Road, Sansad Marg, the Kerala Bhawan side, Ashoka Road and the C-Hexagon. Police monitored crowds through CCTV cameras from the DCP (New Delhi) office and deployed drones, while anti-riot gear was issued to personnel.

The mobilisation quickly escalated when protesters marching from Andhra Bhawan Circle tried to scale police barricades. Scuffles followed, with police claiming that some demonstrators attacked and bit personnel on duty.

Amid the chaos, several political figures and student leaders were detained. AISA National President Neha Bora was picked up during the march. Activists raised alarms on social media, alleging that she was taken away in an unauthorised private vehicle without an official number plate. Protesters tried to stop the vehicle by climbing onto it, while activists also alleged that no female constables were present, calling it a serious procedural violation. Bora was later released from the Narela Industrial Area police station but was reportedly left without her phone and bag.

The mobilisation also drew prominent AAP leaders. More than 25 AAP workers, including Delhi AAP president Saurabh Bharadwaj and MLA Sanjeev Jha, were detained near India Gate. Speaking to reporters after his detention, Bharadwaj said, "They are picking me up and throwing me around like I am a football... There is such a large police force here, yet they are not even registering an FIR against their own ACP, nor are they arresting the ACP..." Bharadwaj also shared a photograph on social media showing him being held upside down by police, which he alleged was done to prevent cameras from capturing his face.

AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal condemned the police action, saying, "This is absolutely shocking. Modi ji has left Hitler behind." The National Students' Union of India (NSUI) also condemned the action after its members were taken into custody while raising slogans against "vote chori" and calling for electoral accountability.

Three women

One of the journalists alleged that an ACP touched her inappropriately and pushed her away when she was recording the police action. The women later approached a police station to lodge complaints, with the complainants alleging that their request for registration of a case was not acted upon immediately.

Delhi Police said the three women approached the police around 6 pm and complained of being manhandled by officers and staff during their detention.

DCP Neha Yadav said their complaints had been registered, medical examinations were conducted and the matter was subsequently transferred to the Crime Branch.

Police also sought relevant video footage from anyone who witnessed or recorded the incidents.

The CJP, however, alleged that police were refusing to register an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat in connection with one of the complaints.

The organisation claimed that its members accompanied the complainant to the Parliament Street police station along with her lawyers but were told that the matter was already being examined by the Crime Branch.

"Our team went inside the police station with the victim and asked them to register an FIR against ACP Vivek Bhagat for molestation, but Delhi Police refused, citing the ongoing Crime Branch investigation," the CJP said in a social media post.

CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said the complainant was present at the police station along with lawyers and party members and questioned why police officials were unwilling to meet them.

The organisation subsequently began a protest outside the station, demanding that the complainant be heard.

"We are outside the Parliament Street Police Station. The Police is unwilling to meet the victim who has been molested by ACP Vivek Bhagat. This is unacceptable! We will continue to stand here until they let us in!" the organisation said in another post.

The CJP also questioned the police's decision to refer the matter to the Crime Branch before registering an FIR, arguing that the complaint should be formally recorded.

The allegations have also triggered concern from the Press Council of India, which expressed dismay over the reported treatment of journalists at the protest. It said media personnel must be allowed to carry out their work without intimidation or aggression and urged Delhi Police to act on the complaint.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi also sought an explanation from Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the allegations, pointing out that Delhi Police comes under the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Gandhi alleged that journalists were dragged and cameras snatched during the protest and questioned the reported delay in acting on the woman journalist's complaint.

The Crime Branch inquiry is now expected to examine the allegations, medical reports and available footage to establish what transpired during the police action.

AIFF polls

The General Body appointed Rajeev Sharma, the former state election commissioner of Haryana, as the electoral officer to oversee and conduct the election process.

It also resolved to extend the tenure of the present AIFF executive committee until December 30, or until the newly elected executive committee assumes office, whichever is earlier.

The elections are being held against the backdrop of a period of uncertainty within the federation, with the AIFF having been working towards aligning its governance structure with its constitution and the requirements of the global and continental governing bodies.

135 years

Urban Affairs had allotted only two rooms at the Kartavya Bhawan-2 complex, raising concerns over the library's future.

The housing ministry, however, rejected reports that the library had been left without space.

In a post on X, it said, "space for the Central Secretariat Library has been provided for in the Kartavya Path redevelopment plan" and added that the construction process was underway.

The Supreme Court's intervention will examine the issue of the library's relocation and accommodation.

Koel Mallick

the same Rajya Sabha seat, this time as a BJP member. Recently, the BJP also nominated three former Trinamool Rajya Sabha MPs—Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Prakash Chik Baraik and Sushmita Deb—after they switched parties. All three are now BJP MPs.

With the BJP enjoying a clear majority in the state Assembly following its victory in 207 seats in the 2026 Assembly polls, her election is expected to be a formality unless there is an unexpected contest.

This development also underlines the BJP's continued effort to draw prominent faces from Bengal's cultural and public spheres into active politics.

The EC has scheduled polling on October 16 and nominations close on October 6, with scrutiny to be held on October 7 and candidates can withdraw till October 9.

Mamata All India Trinamool Congress spokesperson Kunal Ghosh, however, criticised Mamata Banerjee for giving Koel a Rajya Sabha ticket, saying she had proved to be a 'turncoat'

India's Asiad

The first gold came in the 10m air pistol mixed team event, where Suruchi Singh and Kamaljeet prevailed. Neeru Dhanda then produced one of the standout performances of the shooting campaign.

The 27-year-old became the first Indian woman to win an individual Asian Games gold in trap shooting. She also won silver in the women's team event and partnered Kynan Chenai to gold in the mixed team competition.

Several Indian shooters, however, struggled to close out competitions after promising starts, particularly against China and South Korea. The results raised questions about consistency and performance under pressure.

Athletics also fell well short of its Hangzhou performance. India lost one of its leading medal hopes before the competition when javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra withdrew because of injury.

Tajinderpal Singh Toor could not complete a hat-trick of Asian Games gold medals. Long jumper Murali Sreeshankar and high jumper Sarvesh Kushare won silver, while Jyothi Yarraji withdrew from the 100m hurdles before her opening heat after suffering knee discomfort during the warm-up.

Avinash Sable, returning from a serious knee injury, finished fourth in the 3000m steeplechase. India's only athletics gold came in the women's 4x400m relay, where Kiran Pahal, M Poovamma, Prachi Choudhary and Vithya Ramraj won the title. India had won six athletics golds in Hangzhou.

Logistical difficulties also affected the campaign. Accommodation concerns, the lack of a dedicated Games village and transport delays disrupted routines for some athletes. Long journeys to venues and reduced recovery time added to the difficulties, although they do not fully explain the medal decline.

There were, however, important signs that India's sporting base is broadening.

Archery was among the biggest positives.

Teenager Kumkum Mohod became the first Indian to win an individual recurve gold at the Asian Games. India collected five gold, two silver and two bronze medals in archery, matching its total medal tally from Hangzhou.

The recurve team also won medals in all five events, including two golds, two silvers and a bronze, signalling growing competition for South Korea's long-standing dominance.

Wrestling contributed six medals, including two golds. Sujeet Kalkal and Aman Sehrawat defeated Olympic and world champions on their way to the top of the podium, while Greco-Roman wrestlers Nitesh Siwach and Sunil Kumar also won gold.

Tennis, in contrast, ended without a medal for India for the first time in 40 years.

Golf produced a historic result. Pranavi Urs became the first Indian woman to win an individual Asian Games golf gold. Pranavi, Aditi Ashok and Diksha Dagar also won silver in the women's team event, giving India its first women's team golf medal at the Games.

Boxing added three gold medals. Parveen Hooda returned from a 22-month suspension for whereabouts failures to win the women's 65kg title, while Lovlina Borgohain improved on her Hangzhou silver by winning gold.

Ankush Panghal also took gold in the men's 80kg category.

Hockey delivered another major success. India's women ended a 44-year wait for Asian Games gold by defeating defending champions China 1-0. Lalremsiami scored the only goal, while goalkeeper Bichu Devi and veteran Savita Punia played important roles.

The victory also secured direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. India's men retained their Asian Games title and also qualified directly for Los Angeles after beating Malaysia in the final.

Cricket provided another title defence. India's men defeated Pakistan by 19 runs in the final, while the women had already won gold, giving India titles in both tournaments.

Aichi-Nagoya presented two contrasting pictures. Shooting and athletics exposed weaknesses in consistency, preparation and pressure management, while archery, wrestling, boxing, golf and hockey showed that India's medal base is expanding.

The 85-medal haul was below the record set at Hangzhou, but the campaign also produced new champions and historic achievements.

The challenge now is to turn those breakthroughs into sustained performances across more disciplines and ensure India's growing sporting potential is reflected more consistently in its medal count.

Briefs

SP dissolves Gorakhpur units

GORAKHPUR: Left red-faced after a clash among party leaders at a press conference in Gorakhpur, the Samajwadi Party on Sunday dissolved its district, city, frontal and other units.

The incident occurred at the Journalists Press Club during a press conference convened by SP district president Brijesh Gautam to brief the media on the party's "Loktantra Bachao Saptah" campaign from October 2 to 8.

CM Vijay takes out roadshow

DHARAPURAM : TVK president and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay embarked on a roadshow in the Dharapuram Assembly constituency on Sunday in support of his party candidate P Sathyabama ahead of the October 6 bypolls, and slammed the DMK for making remarks against women.

The TVK founder said that attacking women has crossed the line and that he won't remain silent.

Paswan backs SIR

RAIPUR: Union minister Chirag Paswan on Sunday defended the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll and said that while the Election Commission has clarified all points related to the exercise, it must maintain transparency if citizens have doubts.

Speaking to reporters at the Swami Vivekananda Airport here, he emphasised that an independent and impartial EC and unshakeable public faith in its functioning were essential for a healthy democracy.

AAP mocks Cong over defections

PANAJI: The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Goa on Sunday took a swipe at the Congress over the history of defections by its MLAs, sharpening friction within the Opposition ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections.

In 2019, as many as 10 Congress MLAs switched sides to the BJP, while eight more legislators defected to the ruling party in 2022.

Rahul slams BJP over Bihar floods

NEW DELHI: Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Sunday attacked the BJP over the floods in Bihar, saying its 'double-engine' government must explain what has it done over the last 17 years to tackle this annual tragedy and what has actually changed on the ground.

The Congress leader said the people of Bihar need a permanent solution, not just annual relief and assurances.

'STREET ANARCHY CANNOT HIJACK DEMOCRACY'

BJP seeks to debunk Opposition claims on SIR

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4



Supporters of Congress and NCP (SP) hold placards during protest against CEC over alleged irregularities in the SIR of electoral rolls, in Mumbai PTI

Amid protests against SIR and alleged "vote theft", the BJP on Sunday said that the names of 13 crore voters have not been deleted as claimed by the Congress but flagged in the draft electoral roll under categories such as dead, absent, shifted or duplicate.

A "final action" on this follows claims, objections and appeals, the ruling party said on X from its official handle, while posting a "point-by-point breakdown of the claims and facts behind" the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls and accusing the Congress of running a "fear campaign" against SIR.

Rebutting another claim of the Opposition, the BJP asserted that Form 6 was not changed and that an additional declaration was attached for voter convenience.

"Thirteen crore names were not deleted. They were flagged in the draft under categories such as dead, absent, shifted or duplicate. Final action follows claims, objections and appeals," It said.

"Form 6 was not changed. An additional declaration was attached for voter convenience. Electoral rolls remain decentralised, with State Election machinery retaining statutory powers," it added.

The BJP said that a total of 2.37 crore new young voters have been added since June 2025.

"Election Commission decisions are taken collectively by all three commissioners. The electoral process includes BLO verification, party agents, claims and objections, webcasting and monitored counting," it added.

The BJP also asserted that AI (Artificial Intelligence) is not used to delete voters. The decisions are taken by Electoral Registration Officers "under due process".

"The technology has changed, not the framework. The system has gone digital, but all legal powers of the ERO remain intact," the BJP said in another post on X.

Placing "facts on SIR" in a post on X, BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari said more than 2.8 lakh "dead voters" were removed during SIR.

"More than 6 lakh Opposition Booth Agents filed zero complaints," Bhandari said. The BJP leader said the Supreme Court has declared SIR "necessary" for free and fair elections.

"Street anarchy cannot hijack democracy!" he added.

From its official X handle, the BJP rejected as a "lie" claims that the Chief Justice of India (CJI) was removed from the panel that selects the Chief Election Commissioner.

KEY POINTS

- Rebutting another claim of the Opposition, the BJP asserted that Form 6 was not changed and that an additional declaration was attached for voter convenience
- The BJP said that a total of 2.37 crore new young voters have been added since June 2025

Steps up preparedness: Deputy ECs to visit 5 poll-bound states

Functionaries said this week teams from the EC will visit Goa, followed by Uttarakhand next week

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

Senior Election Commission officials led by deputy election commissioners will start visiting the five poll-bound states from this week to oversee election preparedness at the field level.

Functionaries said this week teams from the EC will visit Goa, followed by Uttarakhand next week. The EC officials will also visit Punjab and then Manipur in coming weeks.

There is no word yet on when EC officials will visit Uttar Pradesh.

Usually, the "full Commission" comprising the chief election commissioner and fellow commissioners visits poll-bound states ahead of announcement of election schedule.

While the term of the 403-member Uttar Pradesh Assembly ends on May 22 next year, the terms of 60-member Manipur, 40-member Goa, 117-member Punjab and 70-member Uttarakhand Assembly end on different dates in March, 2027.

THERE IS NO WORD YET ON WHEN EC OFFICIALS WILL VISIT UTTAR PRADESH

Provisions of The Representation of the People Act, 1950 allows EC to hold polls "earlier than six months before the term expires".

As part of poll preparation, Uttar Pradesh and Goa have initiated 'first-level checks' (FLCs) on electronic voting machines and paper trail units to be used in polling.

During FLCs, electronic voting machines and paper trail machines are checked for mechanical flaws by engineers of BEL and ECIL, the two PSUs that manufacture the two equipment. Faulty machines are returned to the manufacturers for repair or replacement.

A mock poll is also held to check the two machines in the presence of representatives of political parties.

The FLCs are an important part of the poll preparedness.

The EC issues a calendar which states have to follow and these checks are part of the schedule.

During FLC, any data from previous elections remaining on the control units and ballot units is completely cleared.

Once a unit passes all diagnostic tests, it is marked as "FLC OK" and sealed with a specialised pink paper seal to prevent any unauthorised access before the next stages of election preparation.

Vigilance probe ordered against CEC

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Thiruvananthapuram, October 4

Keralam Home minister Ramesh Chennithala has ordered a Vigilance probe into the corruption allegations in the KSTP road work project and the death of a Malaysian engineer associated with it in 2006, when incumbent CEC Gyanesh Kumar was serving as the PWD secretary in the state, sources said on Sunday.

The development comes amid protests by the Congress and other opposition parties against Gyanesh Kumar over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across India.

Gyanesh Kumar is a Kerala-cadre IAS officer who headed various departments in the state before moving to central ministries.

Chennithala ordered the probe after KPCC leader Malayinkeezhu Venugopal filed a complaint seeking an investigation against Gyanesh Kumar on Saturday.

Speaking to reporters, Chennithala said he examined the complaint and found prima facie merit in the allegations.

"I am convinced that a detailed Vigilance inquiry is essential," he said

It's not about seats but about victory: Akhilesh

Seat sharing ahead of 2027 UP polls

BISWAJEET BANERJEE
Lucknow, October 4

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav has signalled that the Opposition alliance will prioritise winning the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections over bargaining for individual seats, seeking to project unity among its constituent parties ahead of the polls.

In a post on X, Yadav said the number of seats allocated to each alliance partner or which party contests a particular seat was secondary to ensuring an alliance victory.

"It's not about seats, it's about victory," he said, stressing that the outcome should be seen as a collective victory of all alliance partners and those who have been fighting for the cause.

Yadav said the objective was clear and called for all parties in the alliance to work together.

The SP chief also sought to frame the electoral contest in broader political terms, invoking issues of secularism, democracy, the Constitution and reservation.

He said the alliance's effort would be to ensure that communalism does not raise its head again and that democracy, the Constitution and reservation remain protected.

The message comes as Opposition parties are preparing for the 2027 Assembly elections, with seat-sharing likely to emerge as one of the key issues in alliance negotiations.

Yadav's emphasis on the larger objective appears aimed at signalling that differences over the distribution of seats should not undermine the alliance's electoral prospects.

Cong attacks UP govt over women's safety

BISWAJEET BANERJEE
Lucknow, October 4

Newly appointed Uttar Pradesh Congress president Aradhana Mishra 'Mona' on Sunday launched a sharp attack on the BJP government over women's safety, alleging that Uttar Pradesh has become increasingly unsafe for girls and women.

Referring to a series of incidents reported from different parts of the state over the past week, Mishra said the issue was not limited to individual crimes but reflected what she termed a failure of the system.

"Girls leave home for school but do not return. They become victims of rape and are later killed. If they survive, some become pregnant and in tragic cases, the minor and her child die during childbirth," state Congress chief said in a statement.

Uddhav dubs CEC 'weapon' of BJP, Raj seeks SIR canclation

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Mumbai, October 4



Uddhav Thackeray and Raj Thackeray during the 'Virat Garjana Morcha' rally, in Mumbai, Sunday PTI

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray on Sunday accused Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar of acting as a "weapon" for the ruling BJP, even as MNS leader Raj Thackeray demanded cancellation of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Maharashtra's electoral rolls.

Thousands of people joined the protest march led by the Thackeray cousins in Mumbai against the CEC, which culminated in a rally.

Congress leaders Balasaheb Thorat and Vijay Wadettiwar as well as Jayant Patil, Shashikant Shinde, Jitendra Awhad and Anil Deshmukh of the Sharad Pawar-led NCP (SP) participated in the rally.

The march began from the Metro Cinema and traversed the short distance to the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation headquarters in south Mumbai.

THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE JOINED THE PROTEST MARCH LED BY THE THACKERAY COUSINS IN MUMBAI AGAINST THE CEC

Backing the protesters, Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke, who held a 'Jail Bharo Andolan' against the CEC in Mumbai on Friday, said the city is out on the streets again for free and fair elections. He called for all Indians to come together, saying "it's now or never".

Participants of the agitation, dubbed the Virat Garjana Morcha (Grand Roar March), demanded the removal/resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the SIR process.

Raj Thackeray demanded that future polls in the country be conducted through paper ballot. He also demanded cancellation of the SIR exercise in Maharashtra.

Retrospective environmental clearances: Cong slams BJP

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Sunday slammed the Modi government over the issue of retrospective environmental clearances, and said the "ecologically damaging saga" continues.

The Congress general secretary in-charge communications shared the screenshot of a media report which claimed that the Union Environment Ministry has directed its central and state-level expert bodies to resume processing 'post-facto' environmental clearance (EC) proposals, two months after the Supreme Court permitted it to take such pending, rejected or returned proposals to their logical conclusion in accordance with law.

"The ecologically damaging saga of retrospective environmental clearances continues," Ramesh said on X. On May 16, 2025, a two-judge bench of the Supreme Court had categorically rejected such clearances, the former environment minister said, adding that this was a bold verdict and 100 per cent right.

However, on November 18, 2025, a three-judge bench of the Supreme Court led by the Chief Justice himself by a 2-1 majority overturned the earlier Supreme Court decision, Ramesh said and stressed that this was, to put it most mildly, just wrong.

Thereafter, on July 29, 2026, another three-judge bench of the SC headed by the present CJI unanimously struck down the facility for retrospective environmental clearances provided by the Modi government initially on March 14, 2017 and later reaffirmed in an Office Memorandum on July 7, 2021, he pointed out.

CEILING FAN REMOVAL DEBATE

How foreign universities modified campuses to stop suicides

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

Spring-loaded "anti-suicide" fans, enclosing fans in mesh guards or replacing ceiling fans with wall-mounted units---the physical modifications by Indian education institutions to prevent student suicides might be attracting criticism as "bandaid measures" but the approach has been adopted previously by several foreign universities.

University of Houston (UH) had in 2023 made changes in its infrastructure, including installation of security fencing around the building and temporary barriers to secure the upper-level balconies, inner stairwell and sky bridges, after two students died by suicide on the campus.

Following the incident, the university had created an Agnes Arnold Hall Taskforce and undertook a three-phase renovation.

"The renovation of this facility is a critical step for the university as is the support of our students. With the input of those on the taskforce and others throughout the university, UH also has implemented several initiatives to support our students' mental and academic well-being," Diane Z Chase, senior Vice President for Academic Affairs at University of Houston had said in an announcement in 2024.

At US' Cornell University, a cluster of suicides during the 2009-10 academic year, three of which involved university students jumping from or near East Hill bridges within a month, prompted installation of steel-mesh nets on bridges spanning the gorges around campus.

The university ultimately implemented permanent barriers on eight bridges and fencing around some cliff-edge areas.

Cornell's own account says its consultants had identified the absence of bridge means restriction as a gap in its existing suicide-prevention approach and recommended physical barriers as part of a multi-faceted strategy.

Timothy Marchell, a clinical psychologist and director of the Skorton Centre for Health Initiatives at Cornell Health had then announced that the university also secures access to chemicals, weapons and equipment that could be used as a means of suicide.

Harvard University's "Means Matter" guidelines, based on recommendations contributed by the Suicide Prevention Resource Centre (SPRC) also say that "restricting access to lethal means is one strategy in a comprehensive approach to reducing the risk of suicide on a college campus".

HIGHLIGHTS

- University of Houston (UH) had in 2023 made changes in its infrastructure, including installation of security fencing around the building
- At US' Cornell University, a cluster of suicides during the 2009-10 academic year prompted installation of steel-mesh nets on bridges spanning the gorges around campus

FORM 6 ALTERATION IN FOCUS

Supreme Court to hear pleas for suspension of CEC Kumar today

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, October 4


FILE PIC

HIGHLIGHTS

- A bench of CJI Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana is scheduled to hear the pleas filed by Rakesh Kumar Singh and advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi
- They have also challenged the decisions, guidelines and software changes allegedly made by Kumar without the concurrence of his two colleagues

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas seeking suspension of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and challenging the manner in which the poll panel led by him took decisions, allegedly without the approval of two election commissioners.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana is scheduled to hear the pleas filed by Rakesh Kumar Singh and advocate Shailendra Mani Tripathi, who have also challenged the decisions, guidelines and software changes allegedly made by Kumar without the concurrence of his two colleagues.

The PIL, filed by Patna resident Rakesh Kumar Singh, has urged the top court to determine whether Kumar has been individually exercising powers that legally belong to the Election Commission (EC) as a whole, and, if so, to declare those actions unauthorised and take appropriate legal action.

"Direct that respondent No.3 (CEC) shall not exercise the functions of Chief Election Commissioner of India pending final hearing of the present petition; direct that during such period, the business of the Commission be transacted by the unanimous decision of respondent Nos. 4 (Sukhbir Singh Sandhu) and 5 (Vivek Joshi); and direct that any appointment to the resulting vacancy be made upon the recommendation of a Committee, including the Hon'ble Chief Justice of India," the plea reads.

It demanded suspension of Kumar pending the final hearing of the petition to preserve the "multi-member character of the Election Commission."

The plea comes against the backdrop of an Indian Express report that claimed that election commissioners Sandhu and Joshi objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions and orders on Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls that they said were issued without their knowledge or recommendation

Under fire, the EC said differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberations in any institution and all its orders carry full legal sanction and follow established statutory procedures.

The petition has made the Union Law Ministry, the poll panel, Kumar, Sandhu, Joshi, and Maneesh Garg, a senior official of the poll panel, as parties.

Tripathi's plea, filed through advocate Chand Qureshi, has alleged that the CEC's actions violate the statutory requirement of collective decision-making.

The plea also seeks initiation of criminal proceedings against the CEC and other officials for breach of official duty.

"Divested of any statutory or constitutional immunity, the Chief Election Commissioner remains directly accountable under the law -- subject to police investigation, evidence gathering, and regular trial proceedings as an ordinary accused," the plea states.

Tripathi has relied on the provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023, particularly Section 18, which provides for decision-making by the EC and says that where there is a difference of opinion, the view of the majority prevails.

One of the main issues the plea raises is the alteration of Form 6, which the people use to register as voters. It alleges that the requirement relating to ancestral details and link with the previous SIR was introduced through the election panel's software without the statutory amendment required under the electoral rules.

According to the petition, the two election commissioners other than Kumar objected to the change and asserted that the prescribed form could not be altered without following the statutory procedure.

SIWAN, GOPALGANJ AND EAST CHAMPARAN

At least nine children drown in three districts of Bihar in 3 days

MPOST BUREAU
Patna, October 4

CLOSER LOOK

- Aditya Kumar and Sagar Kumar, both aged 13, drowned while bathing in Daha River in Gopalganj district on Saturday
- 12-year-old Manita Kumari drowned while bathing in Tilawe River in Rohinia village in East Champaran

At least nine children, including four girls, have drowned in Siwan, Gopalganj and East Champaran districts of Bihar in the last three days, police said on Sunday.

Aditya Kumar and Sagar Kumar, both aged 13, drowned while bathing in Daha River in Gopalganj district on Saturday during 'Jitiya', a regional festival during which mothers pray for the long life and prosperity of their children, Mirganj police station SHO Rajeev Ranjan Singh said.

In another incident, 12-year-old Manita Kumari drowned while bathing in Tilawe River in Rohinia village under the jurisdiction of Banjaria police station in East Champaran district around 4 pm on Saturday.

Several people were bathing there on the occasion of the festival when three girls slipped into deep waters. A woman threw her sari and managed to rescue two of them, but Manita Kumari was swept into deeper waters, officials said.

The girl's body was found on Sunday afternoon and sent to Motihari Sadar Hospital for post-mortem, they added.

On Friday, three youths drowned in Khadwa Canal, also in Banjaria police station area, when they went there to celebrate a friend's birthday.

The deceased were identified as Shamir Alam (17), Shakeel Ansari (17) and Yashraj (16), all residents of Chailaha Taal.

Banjaria Circle Officer Krishna Pratap Singh said six youths went to the spot on motorcycles around 3 pm and after the birthday cake was cut, three of them entered the water to take a bath.

The three could not gauge the depth due to the flood situation and drowned in the deep waters of the canal, he added.

Police recovered the bodies and, after post-mortem, handed the mortal remains to their families.

Singh said the next of kin of the boys have been provided cheques under the Disaster Management Department's assistance scheme, while proceedings were underway in the girl's case.

In yet another incident, three girls -- Anshu Kumari (14), Anisha Kumari (16) and Anjali Kumari (16) -- drowned in a pond in Rampur village of Siwan district on Saturday evening.

CM: Every mother, sister of Punjab brand ambassador of 'Satkar Yojna'

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, October 4



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Sunday said every mother and sister in the state was a brand ambassador of the Mawan Dheeyan Satkar Yojna, describing it as a social revolution aimed at strengthening women's dignity, self-respect and financial autonomy.

Mann said more than 75 lakh women had registered under the scheme, with Rs 3,824.87 crore transferred directly into beneficiaries' bank accounts as Satkar Rashi. He said nearly 97 per cent of women in Punjab were eligible and the government had allocated Rs 9,300 crore for the scheme.

The Chief Minister also felicitated Gurmail Kaur, alias Melo, of Adampura village, a beneficiary who gained attention on social media after the scheme's launch. During the meeting, Kaur hugged Mann and blessed him, while he sought her blessings and presented her gifts.

Mann said the government would ensure that no eligible woman was deprived of the scheme's benefits under any circumstances whatsoever.

UP: Ambulance carrying soldier's body crashes into truck, four killed

MPOST BUREAU
Sultanpur, October 4

An Army ambulance carrying the remains of a Subedar Major to his native village in Deoria from Chandigarh collided with a stationary truck on the Purvanchal Expressway here on Sunday, killing four people, including three members of the soldier's family, police said.

The accident occurred around 8 am near the 79.6-km mark in the Haliyapur area, close to the Ayodhya-Sultanpur border. Police said the ambulance went out of control and rammed into a truck parked on the roadside, severely damaging the vehicle. The deceased were identified as Gaurav Singh (28), son of Subedar Major Satyawan, his brother Rajan Chaudhary (35), nephew Ram Samujh Singh (40), and ambulance driver Jaspal (30).

Gaurav Singh and Jaspal died on the spot, while Rajan Chaudhary and Ram Samujh Singh succumbed to their injuries during treatment at a hospital in Pithla-Kumarganj in Ayodhya district, police said.

The four were accompanying the remains of Satyawan, a resident of Galiya Dudhailla village in Rudrapur area of Deoria district.

Police took the bodies into custody and sent them for post-mortem examination. The families of the deceased have been informed.

The remains of Subedar Major Satyawan have been kept at the Haliyapur police station premises pending further arrangements.

Briefs

Bribery case: DGCA official held

NEW DELHI: The CBI arrested DGCA Deputy Director Sushil Kumar Garg and Ekvi Air Training Organisation Director Sachin Keshav Bhane in an alleged Rs 2.5 lakh bribery case, officials said Sunday. Garg allegedly demanded and accepted the bribe for issuing an airworthiness certificate to the private company's aircraft. The agency registered an FIR and conducted raids.

Ex-sarpanch shot dead

LUDHIANA: Two bike-borne assailants allegedly shot dead 55-year-old former sarpanch Navjeet Singh Neetu over a land dispute between two families, police said Sunday. The attackers intercepted his car and fired seven to eight rounds from a .30 bore weapon before fleeing.

UP: 4 held with 14 kg ganja

HARDOI: Four people, including a woman, were arrested for allegedly smuggling around 14 kg of ganja in a luxury car, police said Sunday. Sursa police intercepted the vehicle during checking and recovered the contraband. The accused were identified as Shalini, Pankaj, Nitin and Shiva, police said.

CM meets J'khand's hockey gold winners



MPOST BUREAU
Ranchi, October 4

Jharkhand players from the Indian women's hockey team that won gold at the 2026 Asian Games met Chief Minister Hemant Soren at his official residence on Sunday.

Team captain Salima Tete, along with Nikki Pradhan, Beauty Dungdung and Deepika Soreng, shared their experiences of the team's historic campaign with Soren.

The CM enquired about their preparations and tournament experience, congratulated them and honoured them with traditional shawls. He also offered sweets to celebrate their achievement.

Soren said the players' contribution to India's gold medal-winning performance was a matter of pride for Jharkhand and the country. He praised their talent, discipline, hard work and determination, saying their success had added a new chapter to the state's sporting history.

He said their achievement would inspire young athletes, particularly girls, to excel in sports. Soren also assured that the state government was working to nurture sporting talent.

MLA Kalpana Soren also congratulated the players.

CM woos Singapore investors, showcases Haryana's potential

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, October 4


Haryana CM Nayab Saini and Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai during a meeting with businessmen in Singapore

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday participated in a programme organised by the Singapore Business Federation (SBF) during his visit to Singapore to promote investment and strengthen India-Singapore economic ties.

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai and Indian Ambassador to Singapore Shilpak Ambule were also present at the meeting attended by Singaporean industrialists and business representatives.

Saini highlighted Haryana's investor-friendly policies, industrial potential, infrastructure and facilities, and invited Singapore's business community to explore investment opportunities in the state. Sai outlined Chhattisgarh's investment potential, while Ambule stressed the need to deepen economic and diplomatic relations between the two countries.

Representatives and experts from manufacturing, technology, logistics, energy, education and healthcare participated in discussions on trade and investment cooperation.

During his Singapore visit, Saini also studied facilities at Suntec City's convention centre as part of preparations for a proposed world-class convention centre in Gurugram. He said Haryana would develop the facility over around 25 acres, equipped with modern technology and engineering for international conferences, business meetings, exhibitions and global events. He also studied construction techniques, modern engineering and operational systems at the Singapore facility to understand global standards for the Gurugram project.

Saini said the project would enhance Gurugram's international profile and boost investment and business activity.

He also outlined plans for state-of-the-art infrastructure and a large park in Manesar to improve civic amenities and the green environment overall.

At Gardens by the Bay, Saini studied environmental conservation, plant preservation and advanced water management systems. He also examined measures for water supply and conservation. Indian tourists met Saini and took photographs and selfies with him, while he interacted with foreign visitors.

Pauri: 10-year-old boy killed in road mishap

MPOST BUREAU
Kotdwar, October 4

A 10-year-old boy was killed and another injured after a speeding car allegedly ran over them in the Kotdwar area of Uttarakhand's Pauri district on Sunday, police said.

The police have arrested the accused driver, Abhishek Rawat, and registered a case against him, they said, adding that the vehicle has also been seized.

Kotdwar Circle Officer (CO) Asmita Mamgain said that the incident occurred at 7 am in the Ghamandpur area, where some children were standing by the roadside after playing. Suddenly, an out-of-control car struck two of them -- Vansh, 10, and Lakshya, 12.

The CO said Vansh died on the spot, while Lakshya sustained serious injuries. Lakshya has been admitted to the base hospital.

HP CM's remote village visit blends development outreach with traditions

Visit combines assessment of development and local problems with an immersion in village traditions

ASHWANI SHARMA
Shimla, October 4



KEY POINTS

- Residents welcomed the Chief Minister and his team with traditional hospitality, home-cooked food, music, singing and Nati, the traditional dance of the Shimla hills
- Visuals of the celebrations, including the Chief Minister and members of his entourage joining villagers in singing songs in the local dialect and performing Nati, went viral on social media

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu's three-day visit to remote villages in the Rohru and Rampur Assembly constituencies from October 1 to 3 offered a glimpse of mountain life, with newly opened roads bringing communities that had remained isolated for decades closer to the outside world.

The visit combined an assessment of development and local problems with an immersion in village traditions. Residents welcomed the Chief Minister and his team with traditional hospitality, home-cooked food, music, singing and Nati, the traditional dance of the Shimla hills.

Visuals of the celebrations, including the Chief Minister and members of his entourage joining villagers in singing songs in the local dialect and performing Nati, went viral on social media. Dressed in warm woollen clothes, the visitors followed the dancers' twisting steps as the village came together for the occasion.

State Advocate General Anoop Rattan, Shimla Deputy Commissioner Anupam Kashyap and SSP Gaurav Singh were among those accompanying the Chief Minister. The team spent three days interacting with villagers and women, while local men also shared their views on issues affecting the region.

"The experience was truly memorable. The area is enchanting, and the people warm and hospitable. With better road connectivity and development reaching these remote places, things are changing. Education, too, is bringing new opportunities," Rattan said. The visit also carried political significance as the Rohru and Rampur areas were long associated with six-time Chief Minister Virbhadra Singh, who remained a dominant political figure in Himachal Pradesh for more than five decades.

At the conclusion of the tour, the Chief Minister's Principal Media Advisor said the visit demonstrated that the development of Himachal's hilly areas could not be assessed only through progress in major cities and important towns, but also through conditions in remote villages.

He described the programme as more than a routine administrative exercise, saying it provided an opportunity for direct dialogue between the government and rural communities.

The Chief Minister's emotional connection with Rohru and Rampur was also evident during the visit. He stayed overnight at Bhatwari and Kasha-Pat in Rampur, and is said to be the first Chief Minister of Himachal Pradesh to have stayed overnight in both these areas.

EDITORIAL

Power With Restraint

The reported move by the GST Council to reconsider the arrest and prosecution powers available to tax officials deserves serious attention. Among the proposals under discussion is a possible ₹5 crore threshold for prosecution, alongside changes that could limit the circumstances in which officers exercise arrest powers. The debate goes beyond tax administration. It concerns the balance between the state's legitimate responsibility to combat fraud and the equally important need to ensure that businesses are not exposed to disproportionate criminal action over disputes that can be resolved through ordinary tax proceedings.

There is little argument against strong enforcement where deliberate fraud is involved. Fake invoices, bogus input tax credit claims, shell companies and organised networks designed to evade taxes damage public revenue and place honest businesses at a disadvantage. The government cannot allow sophisticated fraud to hide behind procedural protections. Officers investigating such cases require adequate powers to trace transactions, recover revenue and prosecute those responsible. Weak enforcement would ultimately undermine confidence in the GST system itself.

But arrest is an extraordinary power and should remain so. Tax laws inevitably produce disagreements over classification, valuation, eligibility for input tax credit and interpretation of complex provisions. A commercial disagreement with the tax department should not automatically acquire the character of a criminal offence. When businesses fear that an interpretational dispute could lead to arrest, the consequences extend beyond the individual case. It creates uncertainty, encourages defensive decision-making and weakens the predictable regulatory environment necessary for investment.

A monetary prosecution threshold could therefore provide useful protection, but the amount alone cannot solve the problem. What matters equally is the nature of the alleged offence. A carefully planned fraud involving fabricated transactions is fundamentally different from an incorrect tax position arising from a genuine interpretation of the law. Enforcement must distinguish between intention to deceive and errors or disagreements arising during legitimate business activity. Clear guidelines, written reasons and meaningful supervisory approval before coercive action can strengthen this distinction.

There is also a larger ease-of-doing-business question. India has spent years simplifying taxation, digitising compliance and attempting to reduce unnecessary interaction between taxpayers and officials. Criminal enforcement that appears unpredictable can work against those gains. Businesses need certainty not because they should escape scrutiny, but because investment decisions depend upon confidence that rules will be applied consistently and proportionately.

GST has matured considerably since its introduction, and its enforcement framework should mature with it. The objective cannot be to choose between protecting revenue and protecting taxpayers. Both are essential to a credible tax system. Deliberate fraud must invite firm consequences, but criminal powers should never become shortcuts for recovering disputed dues. The GST Council has an opportunity to establish a clearer principle: enforce vigorously where deception is evident, resolve genuine disputes through due process, and reserve arrest for circumstances where it is demonstrably necessary.

LETTER

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Electoral Safeguards

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan's remarks underline the constitutional importance of protecting every eligible citizen's vote. Electoral rolls certainly require accuracy, but deletion must follow due process, including notice and an opportunity to be heard. Any revision exercise should balance electoral integrity with safeguards ensuring legitimate voters are not inadvertently excluded.

ROHAN MEHTA,
DELHI

You can also send your comments to The Editor, *Millennium Post*, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Nobody Wants to Own Anything

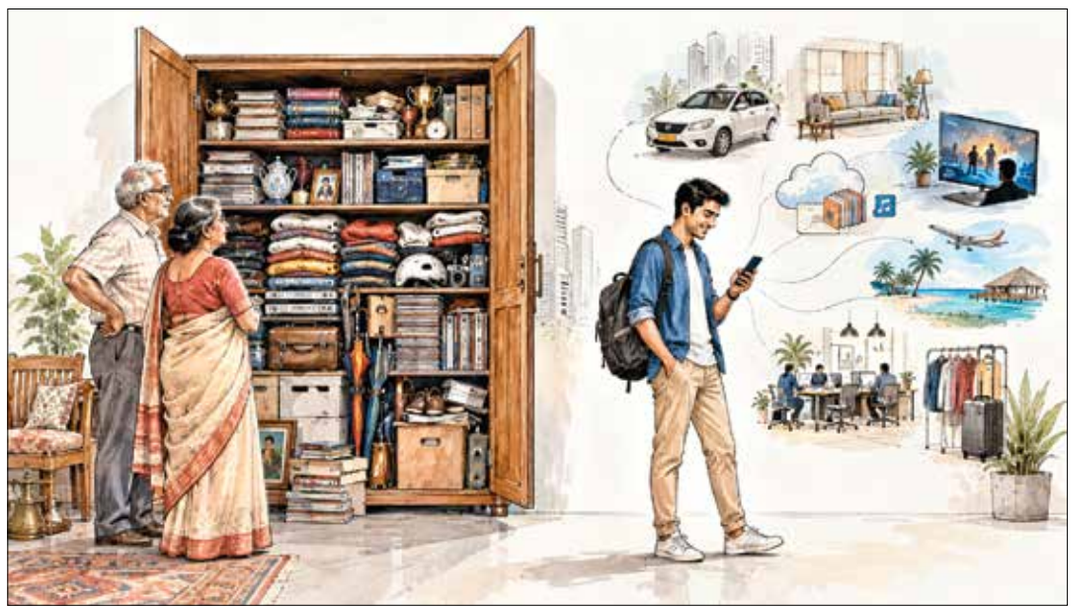
Old India owned things, for that meant having arrived in life. But today's India feels that mere access can be more convenient, cheaper and less troublesome

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A JOURNALIST & COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST



A generation raised on abundance is questioning the need to own everything

"The things you own end up owning you."
— **Chuck Palahniuk**

Something rather fundamental has changed in our lives. More often than not, people don't necessarily want to own the thing. They want to use the thing. Why buy a car that spends most of its life parked when a cab can arrive at the gate within minutes? Why buy pen drives or CDs when millions of songs are available for a subscription with a simple click? Why purchase a movie when a streaming service can provide an entire library?

Software has made this shift overtly obvious. We once bought a program, installed it and expected it to hold our hand. Today, the software we use is rented by the month or year. That logic is spreading. Furniture can be rented. Designer clothes can be rented. Office space can be shared. Cars can be leased. Holiday homes can be booked, not owned.

The proposition is simple. Why carry the cost of possession when you can pay for access, to be used when needed? This has an economic angle too. Ownership comes with maintenance, depreciation, storage, insurance, repairs and, sometimes, the sheer irritation of having to look after something. Access comes with a password.

The Car Has Changed

The car may be the earthiest example. For generations, the first car had been a rite of passage. It represented independence, achievement and adulthood. Parents saved for it. Children dreamed of it. The family washed it on Sunday mornings. Today, a young professional living in a city asks a different question: Why buy a car? There is a cab app. There is the metro. There is a rental for the weekend. In fact, there is a delivery service for everything. Almost.

Owning a car still makes sense for lakhs, particularly families and people living outside urban transport networks. But ownership is no longer the automatic answer to mobility. The change is not that people have stopped wanting cars. It is that ownership of the car is no longer the preferred objective. The same thing is happening with homes, although the shift is slower.

> THE PARENTS WANTED CUPBOARDS FULL OF THINGS. THE NEW GENERATION WANTS NO CUPBOARDS AT ALL

Houses Still Matter

For Indians, a house is different. Emotionally. A rented house can be perfectly comfortable, but owning one still carries a powerful sense of permanence. It is something you can point to and say "this is mine". But younger Indians are far more willing today to move for jobs, change cities, pursue opportunities and postpone buying a home. A 25-year commitment to one location does not sit as comfortably anymore with a workforce that changes employers, cities and careers quicker than ever.

The house, thus, has acquired a competitor: flexibility. This is not the death of home ownership. Far from it. It means the old equation—success equals ownership—is no longer as robotic as it once was.

We Still Want Things

There is an irony here too. We may be moving away from ownership just as consumer choice has exploded. But people still buy expensive phones, watches, cars, shoes and furniture. They still want nice homes. They still collect things.

But a new question is being asked: Do I really need to own this? That is very different from the question previous generations asked. Our parents accumulated things because outright ownership provided security. Things were expensive, sometimes difficult to replace and often unavailable. If you had something useful, you kept it.

Today's young consumer has grown up in a world of abundance and immediate availability. Why keep a cupboard full of DVDs when the movie is available in seconds? Why keep spares of everything when a new one can be delivered in minutes? Why buy a dress for one occasion when it can be rented and returned? This is not about frugality. It is a different, distanced relationship with material things.

New Status Symbol

The biggest change is psychological. For much of the 20th century, prosperity was visible in what was owned. The bigger the house, the newer the car, the larger the television... all of these were convincing evidence that you had done well, arrived in life.

Today, prosperity is being measured by what you do not have to worry about. You do not have to maintain the car. You do not have to store hundreds of films. You do not have to buy an expensive piece of equipment for something you will use twice. You do not even have to remain in the same city.

Convenience has become the new wealth. And time may be the most valuable thing being purchased. Perhaps that is where the ownership revolution really leads to. We have not stopped wanting things. We have simply become less convinced that possessing something is the only way to enjoy it.

Our parents wanted cupboards full of things because things represented security. We may be heading towards a generation that wants fewer cupboards, if any at all. Which is probably bad news for the people who have been storing those mysterious screws. Just in case.

Views expressed are personal

Terror Crisis Without an End

Pakistan's recurring terror attacks expose widening cracks in its security and intelligence apparatus

SECURITY MATRIX



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT

A deadly suicide attack on September 18 in Kohat, in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP), bordering Afghanistan, claimed scores of lives, including 16 police officers, and grievously wounded at least 100 people. The lethal terror assault, lasting several hours and involving a car bomb, a suicide bombing and multiple armed attackers, indicates the continuing trend of terrorism in Pakistan.

According to a report in The New York Times (NYT), an alliance led by powerful extremist leader Hafiz Gul Bahadur, whose fighters once targeted US and NATO forces in Afghanistan, claimed responsibility for this assault on a mosque inside a police compound in Pakistan. Bahadur's group is widely suspected of having active links with the notorious Al Qaeda. Gul Bahadur is one of the longest-surviving commanders whom both US and Pakistani forces have failed over the years to neutralise. His re-emergence could possibly mean spiralling violence in western Pakistan and a further worsening of relations with Afghanistan. The attack highlights Bahadur's intricate network and its ability to execute "complex, serious attacks on security forces", as per Elizabeth Threlkeld, director of the South Asia Program at the Washington-based Stimson Center.

It may also be stressed that the detonation of an explosives-laden vehicle outside the mosque began the assault on the compound on the afternoon of September 18. Armed terrorists then entered the complex and battled security forces for hours; a suicide bomber even detonated explosives near a facility of the police's intelligence unit. Police, on their part, claimed that eight attackers had been killed. It is also relevant to mention here that a UN report in August noted the group's global linkages. Al Qaeda's affiliate in the region had "formed the backbone" of Bahadur's network, the report said.

In the aftermath of recent multiple terrorist incidents, Pakistan carried out an intelligence-based ground operation and airstrikes targeting terrorist safe havens in parts of KP, including in the border region with Afghanistan. Authorities described it as a well-planned, intelligence-based ground operation executed by the security forces around Kohat, Hangu and Thal, followed by calibrated airstrikes against the hideouts and safe havens of terror organisations responsible for these attacks.

Pakistani security officials later claimed that their counterterrorism campaign, Ghazab Lil Haq, under the vision Azm-e-Istehkam, would continue at full pace to exterminate the menace of foreign-sponsored and supported terrorism from the country. However, they did not clarify or elaborate on what they meant by "foreign-sponsored".



Pakistan continues struggling to contain terror networks operating across its borders

> KOHAT'S DEADLY ASSAULT UNDERSCORES THE URGENT NEED TO RECALIBRATE PAKISTAN'S COUNTERTERRORISM STRATEGY

Meanwhile, continuing its reaction to the deadly terror strike, Pakistan's print media maintained its tirade. Prominent daily Dawn, in its September 20 editorial, said that the attack in Kohat marked a further escalation by Pakistan's enemies.

Further inputs, according to Dawn, reveal that The Ittehadul Mujahideen, an umbrella organisation of terrorist outfits, is, according to the Jamestown Foundation think tank, believed to operate from safe havens across the border, share intelligence and coordinate attacks with its terrorist factions. It has apparently used drone technologies to effect while targeting security forces and installations in the past. As such, it is thought in some professional circles to be a more serious and sophisticated threat than the Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP).

The media also recommends that the KP police must be better equipped and trained. They are facing an enemy that is increasingly using modern technology to cause bloodshed. They must have the equipment, strategies and technologies they need to effectively limit and counter the constant, deadly threat they face. Simultaneously, the authorities need to review the approaches being taken to counter violent perpetrators. National policy on counterterrorism requires recalibration and revisiting, especially regarding its diplomatic, political and social aspects, which must be addressed together to secure stable dividends, as per media observations.

This fresh terror attack in Kohat reveals Pakistan's inherent chinks in the armour. It is clear that its intelligence apparatus is rusted, as no actionable intelligence was received by the authorities that could have been centralised. This is of particular concern for the forces on the ground, as intelligence along the Pakistan-Afghanistan border is crucial. Besides, repeated terror attacks have now become a pattern in Pakistan. Targeting mosques and police establishments is more routine than exceptional. And that is what is happening at regular intervals. There is also a complete lack of coordination and intelligence-sharing with or from Pakistan's "friendly countries", with which it is supposed to exchange vital intelligence on security concerns. After all, the organisation that claimed to have perpetrated the attack is believed to be linked to Al Qaeda. If the intelligence agencies are so complacent about a global threat like Al Qaeda, then it is difficult to fathom their priorities. Due to continued indifference on Pakistan's part, the region is becoming increasingly volatile and vulnerable.

Pakistan perhaps has lost its focus on the most important issue of terrorism and has strayed into "mediating truces" or entering into defence pacts. Yet, both these endeavours have failed to pay any dividends. It is high time it paid attention to security on its borders with Afghanistan to thwart terror attacks, particularly when they are occurring so frequently. It is a sad commentary on its policy of tackling terror even 25 years after 9/11, when Al Qaeda and the terrorists wreaked havoc.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Pro-Ukraine coalition wins 35% in Latvian election

RIGA: Latvian lawmakers on Sunday planned to begin negotiations to form a new government following a parliamentary election in which pro-Ukraine PM Andris Kulbergs's four-party coalition emerged with 35 per cent of the vote.

A political crisis in May over the handling of stray drones suspected of coming from Ukraine brought down the governing coalition that had been under strain over several other issues. The parliament, then approved the coalition led by Kulbergs of the centrist United List party.

Jay Clayton named as US government's new AI czar

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump on Sunday tapped Jay Clayton, his director of national intelligence, to lead a new government task force on artificial intelligence.

Trump is calling it the "Super Intelligence Force" because he has tried to rebrand AI as "super intelligence." The announcement comes after Trump hosted top executives of AI companies at the White House last week and said they had signed a voluntary accord that would effectively self-police the development of the technology.

Brazil presidential vote pits Trump ally against Lula

SAO PAULO: Brazilians began voting Sunday in a high-stakes presidential election pitting incumbent Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva against Sen. Flávio Bolsonaro, ideological opposites who are each seen as having a shot at an outright victory.

If no candidate gets more than 50 per cent of the vote, the top two vote-getters will head to a runoff on Oct. 25 in Latin America's economic powerhouse. Ten other candidates are expected to garner much smaller numbers of votes on Sunday.



Chiefs attend the Akuapem State's 200th anniversary celebration of the Odwira Festival in Ghana's Akropong on Friday AP/PTI

Briefs

Pak: Imran's party begins long march

ISLAMABAD/ PESHAWAR: Pakistan's former prime minister Imran Khan's party on Sunday began its long march towards Islamabad from Khyber Pakhtunkhwa following the failure of negotiations with the government.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Chief Minister Sohail Afridi set off from Lakki Marwat's Gandi Chowk, saying he would announce his next course of action on Thursday, October 8, when Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf's convoy reaches Khairabad.

2 people killed in Norway

HALDEN: Two people were killed and another seriously injured Sunday when a shooter opened fire on a hunting party in southern Norway, police said.

The suspect was arrested at the scene and is not believed to be part of the hunting party, police said in a statement. The injured victim was flown to a hospital for treatment.

The shooting occurred near Halden, which is about 96 kilometres (60 miles) from Oslo and near the Swedish border.

Other details were not immediately available.

B'desh: 7 idols vandalised

DHAKA: Seven idols being sculpted for Durga Puja at a Hindu temple in Bangladesh have been vandalised by unidentified miscreants, according to a local media report.

The incident took place in Tangail district between Wednesday night and Thursday morning at a temple in Jamurki Paschimpara in Mirzapur upazila, according to the Daily Star newspaper.

Durga Puja has been celebrated at the temple for around 85 years under the auspices of the Jamurki Arya Samiti, the report said.

Seven idols, including the main Durga sculpture, were nearly complete when the incident happened.

The artisans had finished most of the sculpting.

INFO INCLUDES PILOTS' NAMES & NATIONALITIES

UAE shared details about FlyDubai flight with Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Tel Aviv, October 4



Dubai Crown Prince Hamdan bin Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum meets Captain Smit Machchhar PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cockpit's crash axe
- The Co-pilot's actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before the Indian captain managed to open the cockpit door

Authorities in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the FlyDubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection.

With the investigation underway, preliminary details about the incident have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials have already said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views.

It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab country that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to fly a plane loaded with Israelis to Tel Aviv.

The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cockpit's crash axe and tried to take control of the plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack" on Wednesday.

His actions nearly crashed the flight with 182 people on board before the Indian captain managed to open the cockpit door, allowing passengers and others to rush in and subdue the attacker.

The regional officials said Emirati authorities had shared information about the passengers and crew, including their nationalities.

Israel hadn't raised red flags on any passenger or member of the crew, said the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to reporters about the probe.

The Shin Bet, Israel's domestic security agency, said the Transportation Ministry is responsible for vetting passenger lists from foreign flights. Transportation Minister Miri Regev told Israel's public broadcaster Kan, that the security agencies are responsible for flight security and that her ministry wasn't given a list of passengers or any warnings.

Strait of Hormuz will not reopen until conditions are met: Iran

Tehran presented a proposal during the UNGA

AGENCIES
Dubai, October 4



The Strait of Hormuz will not reopen until seven Iranian conditions set out in a June interim agreement with the US are met, state media reported Iran's parliament speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf as saying on Sunday.

Iran presented a proposal during the UN General Assembly under which the Strait of Hormuz waterway could be reopened and normal maritime passage restored within seven days if the conditions were met, with the US replying to this proposal last week via Qatari intermediaries.

"The position of the Islamic Republic of Iran is completely clear and firm, and the Strait of Hormuz will not be opened until our seven conditions, based on the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding, are met," Qalibaf, who is Iran's top negotiator, was quoted as saying.

He said Washington "must understand that the period of dragging out the (diplomatic) process and dictating one-sided demands is over".

A Foreign Ministry spokesperson said on Sunday that Tehran had clarified its broad positions via mediators to the US response but that additional points remained to be communicated to Washington.

"The Americans' proppositions are more or less in line with their previous positions, specifically on the nuclear issue. We told them our focus in this stage is the issue of the Strait of Hormuz and the return to security in this waterway requires clear steps from the US," spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei said.

He also denied Tehran had offered UN nuclear watchdog inspections of its nuclear facilities in exchange for US sanctions relief, saying Iran had not entered into nuclear discussions with Washington.

Israeli strike kills one Palestinian in Gaza

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai, October 4

An Israeli strike Sunday morning on a civilian vehicle killed one Palestinian and wounded at least 11 others, according to health officials at the Aqsa Martyrs Hospital, where the casualties were taken.

Israel's military said it targeted a known Hamas militant in the strike.

Palestinians in Gaza have reported a surge in Israeli fire and airstrikes across the enclave over the past month. Israel says it is targeting Hamas and other militants who pose a threat, and in response to ceasefire violations, including occasional attacks.

Germany's Merz announces new aid for Ukraine

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Kyiv, October 4

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced a new aid package for Ukraine worth more than 1.3 billion euros (USD 1.5 billion) during a visit to Kyiv on Sunday, as Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities.

The aerial war has intensified, with Moscow menacing cities across Ukraine with hard-to-intercept ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones, while Kyiv has been striking Russia's oil industry and businesses.

About 1 billion euros (USD 1.1 billion) of the package is military aid, including long-range strike weapons, combat drones and satellite technology, "so that Ukraine can also target Russian launch pads," Merz said at a news conference.

Germany is also providing some 350 million euros (USD 395 million) in energy aid ahead of winter for generators, substations and repair work, he said.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the two countries also signed 15 agreements worth more than 8.5 billion euros (USD 9.6 billion), mostly covering security cooperation, weapons production and procurement, as well as a deal to expand their joint counter-drone efforts.

Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals repatriated from Malaysia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Yangon, October 4

Nearly 1,500 Myanmar nationals who were sent back from Malaysia arrived in the country's largest city on Sunday, despite warnings from the United Nations refugee agency and rights groups that conditions for return remain unsafe.

Myanmar has been in turmoil since the military seized power from the elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi on Feb. 1, 2021, triggering widespread opposition and plunging large parts of the country into conflict.

The returnees, including 86 women, have been convicted of staying illegally and other immigration violations in Malaysia, according to reports from Myanmar state media.

They were transported from Malaysia aboard two navy warships and a hospital ship last Tuesday. They arrived in southern Yangon early Sunday, Nay Lin Tun, a regional government minister, said.

Yemen's govt declares major operation against Houthis

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai, October 4

Yemen's government has announced a major military operation against the Iran-backed Houthi rebels as they advance on the outskirts of a key city.

Meanwhile, an Israeli strike has killed at least one person in Gaza as Palestinians report a recent surge in such strikes across the enclave. And Iran's top diplomat says Tehran is still open to diplomacy.

Rashad al-Alimi, head of the ruling Presidential Leadership Council, made the declaration as the Iran-backed rebels advanced in the outskirts of a key southwestern city, Taiz.

Speaking from Saudi Arabia, he said the operation aims at "recovering the remaining territories" controlled by the Houthis, who made their largest land grab in recent years last month when they seized Yemen's Red Sea coast and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait.

Al-Alimi called for the international community to provide support to his Saudi-backed government.

Bangladesh seeks Hasina's extradition from India

The 79-year-old Sheikh Hasina has been living in India since fleeing Dhaka on August 5, 2024

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Dhaka, October 4



Sheikh Hasina

Bangladesh on Sunday said it expected India to expedite the extradition of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, saying that besides the legal process, "political intent" was also necessary for her return.

The remarks came a day after Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi said India could not give a timeframe for Hasina's return as Dhaka's extradition request was being examined through a legal process involving the courts.

"There is certainly a legal process involved, but political intent is also necessary," State Minister for Foreign Affairs Shama Obaed Islam told a media briefing at her office.

She expressed hope that India would take steps to expedite the extradition process. Responding to whether former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina could be repatriated under the active extradition treaty between New Delhi and Dhaka, the state minister said "certainly."

"The accused (Hasina) can be brought back under the treaty, and that process is being taken forward," she said, though some legal experts have questioned whether the treaty applies in her case.

"Nobody can give you a timeframe (over Hasina's return)," Trivedi had said on Saturday at a discussion organised by a private think tank in Dhaka.

"Again and again, the government of India has replied to this that there is a process, and the process is legal, and it is well structured," he said.

Hasina, 79, has been living in India since fleeing Dhaka on August 5, 2024, after a student-led agitation, dubbed the July Uprising, toppled her Awami League government.

A special tribunal later tried Hasina in absentia and sentenced her to death over the crackdown on the protests. Hasina and her supporters have described it as a "kangaroo court".

JIO PLATFORMS IPO IS TOUTED AS INDIA'S LARGEST PUBLIC OFFER

Jio Platforms IPO likely by Oct end at enterprise valuation of $143-146 bn

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

Digital services major Jio Platforms is likely to get listed by the end of this month at an enterprise valuation of $143-146 billion or above Rs 12 lakh crore, sources tracking the development said. Jio Platforms IPO is touted as India's largest public offer at an estimated size of $3.8 billion.

The company has concluded overseas roadshows and is expected to file final papers with market regulator SEBI for the initial public offering in the week starting October 12, banking and other sources who did not wish to be identified said.

"Based on interest received from overseas roadshows, Jio Platforms is likely to list at a base enterprise valuation of $143-146 billion or at least Rs 12 lakh crore by end of this month," one of the banking sources said.

An email sent to Jio Platforms (JPL) seeking comments based on available information did not elicit any reply. The overseas roadshows held in the US, UK, Dubai, Hong Kong and Singapore were led by Jio Platforms Managing Director and Reliance Jio Chairman Akash Ambani and Reliance Retail Ventures Limited Executive Director Isha Ambani.



One of the event vendors said that JPL is expected to hold a roadshow for the IPO in India in the week starting October 12 after filing the red herring prospectus.

According to banking sources, Jio Platforms is expected to start an anchor round before Dussehra and the issue is expected to open post-Dussehra before October 23.

"The company is expected to list on the stock exchange by the end of this month," the source said.

The SEBI issued its final observations on August 28. Jio Platforms had filed its draft IPO papers in June.

According to its draft prospectus, the company plans to issue up to 27 crore fresh equity shares, equivalent to about 2.9 per cent of its post-issue equity base.

Sources have indicated that the company may raise around $3.8 billion from the offer. The public offering comes as India's primary market has remained active, with strong participation from retail investors and domestic institutions.

More than two dozen IPOs have been announced or launched since July 1, nearly matching the 28 recorded in the first half of 2026. Jio Platforms houses Reliance's digital businesses, including its telecom operations.

Reliance Jio Infocomm, the telecom arm of JPL, dominates the Indian telecom market with a 32.89 per cent market share in fixed-line connections, serving 157.9 million customers, and a 39.29 per cent share in mobile connections, with 506 million customers.

JPL has the largest 5G Standalone network outside China, with 26.85 crore 5G customers as of June 2026. Jio leads the Fixed Wireless Access segment globally with about 1.5 crore subscribers, roughly 1.5 times the second-largest player, US-based T-Mobile.

Jio claims that its 5G network's carrying capacity is close to 60 per cent of India's wireless data traffic, one of the largest in the world. Leveraging its network and data traffic capacity, Jio has expanded its business into other areas of the digital ecosystem, including cloud, artificial intelligence and enterprise network services.

For FY26, Jio Platforms posted a 15 per cent rise in profit after tax to Rs 30,053 crore and a 14.5 per cent increase in the annual revenue to Rs 1,46,885 crore.

Analysts at Nuvama Research expect Reliance Jio's profit after tax to clock a compounded annual growth rate of 18 per cent between FY26 and FY30, at par with the oil and gas vertical of parent firm Reliance Industries Limited.

Jio Platforms has previously drawn major global technology and financial investors - in 2020, Meta invested Rs 43,574 crore for a 9.99 per cent stake, while Google invested Rs 33,737 crore for a 7.73 per cent holding.

Other investors, including Silver Lake, Vista Equity Partners, General Atlantic, KKR, Mubadala, Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, TPG, L Catterton, Intel Capital and Qualcomm Ventures collectively invested about Rs 74,745 crore for roughly a 15.2 per cent stake.

Reliance Industries owns about 66.4 per cent of Jio Platforms, and Meta and Google together hold about 17.7 per cent, according to the draft prospectus.

The IPO would be the first public offering from the Reliance group since 2008 and the first IPO of a consumer-focused business within the conglomerate.

KEY POINTS

- The company is expected to file final papers with market regulator SEBI for the IPO in the week starting October 12
- According to banking sources, Jio Platforms is expected to start an anchor round before Dussehra and the issue is expected to open post-Dussehra before October 23

Auto makers boost production and dealer stocks to meet festive demand

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4



Leading automakers are ramping up production and building dealer inventory to meet strong customer demand as India enters the peak festive buying season, with manufacturers seeking to ensure adequate vehicle availability and convert healthy bookings into retail sales.

Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India has 2.2 lakh pending bookings ahead of the festive season, while Hyundai Motor India has built four-five weeks of inventory across its dealer network. Mahindra & Mahindra, meanwhile, has scaled up its utility vehicle and electric vehicle manufacturing capacity to 68,000 units a month to improve supply and bring down waiting periods.

Maruti Suzuki India's Senior Executive Officer Partho Banerjee told PTI, "At the beginning of this financial year, we had 12 days of stock. The current bookings pendency is 2.2 lakhs, which translates to 16 days of stock before the festive season.

"We have already commissioned two new production lines, adding 5 lakhs capacity in total. The production is being ramped up gradually, and we expect these lines to fully stabilise by year-end.".He shared that the company is calibrating production and supplies across models to prevent waiting periods from rising disproportionately for individual vehicles during the festive period.

"For Maruti Suzuki, our supply chain and production teams are putting in efforts and trying to meet the festival demand. However, due to supply constraints, we may introduce special schemes for our pending booking customers," Banerjee said.

Tarun Garg, MD & CEO, Hyundai Motor India Ltd, said, "The festive season continues to be a key growth driver for the Indian automotive industry, and we have been proactively preparing our operations, dealer network and supply chain to effectively cater to customer demand across the country."

"Over the past few months, we have strengthened dealer inventory, optimised logistics and enhanced product availability across the Hyundai Motor India Limited network to support timely deliveries and a seamless customer experience," he added.

Garg shared that Hyundai Motor India Ltd has proactively built dealer inventory ahead of the festive season, with inventory levels of 4-5 weeks across its network, to effectively cater to anticipated festive demand.

"Our focus remains on maintaining the right balance between fulfilling existing customer bookings and ensuring adequate stock availability at dealerships to maximise retail conversions during the festive period," he added.

Nalinikanth Gollagunta, CEO, Automotive Division, Mahindra & Mahindra Ltd., said demand remains robust across its portfolio.

"Over the first half of the year, we scaled up our SUV and EV manufacturing capacity to 68,000 units per month to cater to growing customer demand.

This has helped us significantly improve supply-side responsiveness and bring down waiting periods across the portfolio, even as bookings have remained healthy," Gollagunta observed.

OPEC+ agrees to keep November oil output targets steady

AGENCIES
London/Moscow, October 4

OPEC+ agreed to keep oil production targets unchanged for November at a meeting on Sunday, signalling that further output policy changes are unlikely until next year.

Gulf OPEC+ producers have been pumping below targets amid continuing export disruptions from the US-Israeli war on Iran, with exports at 60-80 per cent of normal levels in recent months, *Reuters* reported.

UBS analyst Giovanni Staunovo said output remained well below quotas despite rising flows through the Strait of Hormuz, keeping the oil market tight. The conflict has also delayed OPEC+'s capacity review, crucial for determining 2027 production quotas, amid uncertainty over future production potential.

The seven core members pumped 25 million bpd in August, up 630,000 bpd from July but about 5 million bpd below February's prewar levels.

The group's next meeting is on November 1.

Let exchange rate absorb Fed hike impact: IMF suggests India

AGENCIES
Washington, October 4

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) has said the US Federal Reserve's interest rate hike would tighten global financial conditions and suggested India allow the exchange rate to act as a shock absorber.

An IMF spokesperson on Friday said Fed rate hikes have historically pressured emerging markets through capital flows, financing conditions and exchange rate movements. On September 17, the Federal Reserve raised interest rates for the first time since July 2023 and indicated another hike could follow to combat inflation.

The impact on India would depend on the magnitude, pace and persistence of the tightening cycle, along with domestic economic conditions, the spokesperson said.

India, however, enters the period with strong growth momentum, a credible inflation-targeting framework, ample external buffers and healthy corporate and financial sector balance sheets, strengthening its resilience, the spokesperson said. "Allowing the exchange rate to act as a shock absorber, while keeping monetary policy focused on domestic price stability, remains an effective approach," the spokesperson said.

GVC integration, supply chain resilience, better utilisation of FTAs key to boost exports: Deloitte

AGENCIES
New Delhi, October 4

Deepening integration into global value chains (GVCs), strengthening supply chain resilience and better utilisation of FTAs are key to boosting India's exports and high-end manufacturing, Deloitte India said.

Anil Talreja, Partner, Deloitte India, said India needs to cut logistics costs via multimodal export corridors, focusing on end-to-end supply chain efficiency. This includes lowering costs related to port handling, transportation, warehousing, rail connectivity, container availability and last-mile logistics.

He suggested setting up a 'Response Cell' to track changes in standards, carbon-border adjustment measures, product regulations, sustainability and traceability requirements, sanctions and other trade-related requirements in major export markets.

India's export-led manufacturing should move beyond scale and assembly towards technology, value addition and deeper GVC integration, he said. High-potential sectors include electronics and semiconductors, pharmaceuticals, capital goods, defence and aerospace, speciality chemicals & clean technologies.

Deloitte also called for assessing critical supply-chain vulnerabilities and addressing them through alternative suppliers, technology partnerships, domestic production and strategic reserves. It recommended aligning FTAs with industrial policy, rationalising tariffs & supporting MSMEs in meeting rules of origin, standards and documentation requirements.

MSMEs account for about 48.58 per cent of India's exports and 45 per cent of manufacturing. Talreja also highlighted their challenges in accessing affordable trade finance and managing payment and currency risks.

DLF sells 172 senior living homes in Gurugram

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

Realty major DLF Ltd on Sunday said it has sold all 172 senior living homes for Rs 1,985 crore at Gurugram, amid high demand for luxury housing properties.

In a regulatory filing, DLF, the country's largest real estate firm, announced a "complete sell-out" of its newly launched project 'The Aureva' meant for senior citizens. The project, spread across 4.17 acres, is located at Sector 63, Gurugram.

"The project has achieved sales of about Rs 1,985 crore, underscoring strong demand for thoughtfully curated luxury retirement living communities that seamlessly integrate luxury, wellbeing, convenience, healthcare access, and meaningful community engagement," DLF said.



THE COMPANY HAD GIVEN AN ANNUAL SALES BOOKINGS GUIDANCE OF Rs 20,000 CRORE FOR FY27

The average price realisation is Rs 11.5 crore per apartment. The units were sold at Rs 28,000 per sq ft.

The company is developing 172 luxury residences in this upcoming project with a total carpet area of over 4 lakh square feet and a total saleable area of over 7.5 lakh square feet. Aakash Ohri, MD & Chief Business Officer, DLF Home Developers Ltd, said the project represents "DLF's vision of redefining luxury retirement housing in India."

The project will have a professionally managed on-site medical centre with emergency response support. "Once again, this project's strong market performance underscores the growing demand for premium, experience-led residential offerings in India in this segment," Ohri said.

DLF has developed more than 185 real estate projects with an area of more than 352 million square feet. The company had given an annual sales bookings guidance of Rs 20,000 crore for the current 2026-27 fiscal.

RBI's interest rate decision, oil prices to drive market this week

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

RBI's interest rate decision, TCS' earnings, crude oil prices and global bond yields will be important factors to determine stock market movement this week, analysts said.

Macroeconomic data announcements and foreign investors' trading activity will also guide market trends, they added.

"RBI's monetary policy meeting will be closely watched. The policy stance, inflation outlook and growth projections will provide important cues on the near-term trajectory of domestic interest rates and financial markets.

"This week will also mark the beginning of the earnings season, with index heavyweight TCS and retail major DMart among the key companies scheduled to announce their results," Ajit Mishra, SVP - Research, Religare Broking, said.

On the data front, India's final HSBC Services PMI and Composite PMI readings for September are scheduled to be released on October 6, he said. TCS is slated to announce its September quarter earnings on October 8.

Indian equities ended lower for the eighth consecutive week as foreign selling, rupee weakness, elevated crude and rising global bond yields weighed on sentiment.

Last week, the Sensex tanked 1,986.04 points, or 2.68 per cent, and the Nifty plunged 718.55 points, or 3.10 per cent.

Industrial production data flags growing gap between textiles, apparel mfg

Wearing apparel, one of the 23 manufacturing industries, has witnessed a contraction of 7.4 per cent in August

AGENCIES
New Delhi, October 4

India's output grew 8 per cent in August 2026 against 6.7 per cent in the previous month, but data showed contraction in apparel production even as textile manufacturing maintained a strong growth.

Within manufacturing, 18 of 23 industry groups recorded positive growth over the year-ago month, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) said.

Wearing apparel, one of the 23 manufacturing industries and the bellwether of India's exports, has witnessed a contraction of 7.4 per cent in August and a cumulative year-on-year decline of 5.6 per cent during the April-August period of the current financial year.

In contrast, the textile industry, which feeds apparel manufacturing, has recorded a strong growth of 13.1 per cent in August and a cumulative expansion of 11.9 per cent in the current fiscal year so far.

Textile production carries 3.27 points in the 100-point IIP, while wearing apparel accounts for 1.97 points. Manufacturing has 76 points.

A Sakthivel, Chairman of the Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPC), said the indices cover different production stages and "need not necessarily move in line with overall industrial output". He said textile manufacturing covers upstream yarn and fabric segments influenced by raw-material prices, inventory and intermediate demand, while apparel, the final value-added stage, is more directly linked to export orders, buyer inventories and retail demand. Geopolitical and trade uncertainties can therefore affect apparel production more quickly.

Apparel production fell 2 per cent in September and over 7.3 per cent in October last year before rising 6.7 per cent in November and over 17 per cent in December. This year, it declined 8.6 per cent in January and 3.4 per cent in February, rose 4.8 per cent in March, but fell over 10 per cent in April. It grew 3.6 per cent in May and 2.3 per cent in June before contracting 2.3 per cent in July and 7.2 per cent in August.

Textile production saw a fall of 7.7 pc in October 2025. It declined 5.7 per cent in January and 24.2 per cent in February, before rebounding 48 per cent in March and staying at that level through August.

The sector accounts for around 2 per cent of GDP and 11 per cent of manufacturing GVA, according to National Accounts Statistics 2025. The textile market was Rs 14.95 lakh crore, including Rs 12.02 lakh crore domestically, 80 per cent. India aims to raise apparel exports to $40 billion by 2030 from around $16 billion.

Apparel exports declined 9.1 per cent during April-August 2026-27. Sakthivel said new FTAs and market diversification could support recovery, but contraction could affect manufacturing, value addition, exports, investment and employment.

"The manufacturing growth is slow, but it is cyclical. The growth will pick up in two to three months. We are making Christmas orders at present," said Sharad Saraf, CMD of Technocraft Industries.

CLOSER LOOK

- The apparel manufacturing industry also witnessed a cumulative year-on-year decline of 5.6 per cent during the April-August period of the current financial year
- In contrast, the textile industry, which feeds apparel manufacturing, has recorded a strong growth of 13.1 per cent in August and a cumulative expansion of 11.9 per cent so far in the current financial year

AFTER RATE OVERHAUL

GST set for next big reform, arrest powers of officers may be scrapped

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

GST Council is likely to consider this week a sweeping rewrite of GST enforcement that would take arrest powers away from tax officials and require a court order for any arrest, people familiar with the proposal said, in what could become the next major pillar of the government's Next-Generation GST reforms.

The GST Council, the apex decision-making body on the Goods and Services Tax (GST), is also likely to consider, at its October 7 meeting, a package of prosecution-related reforms, including raising the threshold for launching criminal proceedings for offences to Rs 5 crore.

The proposals also seek to narrow the scope of prosecution provisions so they do not apply to routine disputes over classification, valuation or Input Tax Credit (ITC), where businesses and tax authorities may hold differing interpretations of the same transaction, they said.



The proposed enforcement changes are part of the government's Next-Generation GST reform agenda, following the major rate rationalisation implemented in September 2025. That overhaul simplified the GST structure around a 5 per cent merit rate and an 18 per cent standard rate, with a 40 per cent rate for select luxury and demerit goods.

The next phase is expected to focus on simplifying administration, reducing compliance costs and making enforcement more proportionate.

A wider package under consideration includes easier registration, faster refunds, simpler input-tax-credit procedures and changes to show-cause notices and penalties, the people said.

At the centre of the enforcement proposal is Section 69 of the Central GST Act, which allows the Commissioner, where statutory conditions are met, and there are reasons to believe specified offences have been committed, to authorise an officer to arrest a person. The proposed changes would remove that power from tax officials. Any arrest would instead require judicial authorisation, they noted.

They said the proposed changes would not remove the government's ability to recover taxes or impose financial penalties. Compounding would allow an offence to be settled, subject to payment of the prescribed tax, interest and penalty. Taxpayers found to have short-paid tax or wrongly claimed input tax credit would continue to face recovery proceedings and other statutory consequences.

Serious cases involving deliberate evasion or fraud could continue to be prosecuted through the courts, they said.

KEY POINTS

- The GST Council is also likely to consider, at its October 7 meeting, a package of prosecution-related reforms
- The proposals also seek to narrow the scope of prosecution provisions so they do not apply to routine disputes over classification, valuation or ITC

The move would also fit into the government's broader effort to decriminalise economic and regulatory offences. The Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2026, sought to decriminalise a range of provisions across central laws, while changes to income-tax recovery rules have also reduced the role of arrest and detention.

The GST Council has previously considered decriminalising minor offences, raising prosecution thresholds and making compounding provisions more accessible.

For businesses, the proposed change would reduce the possibility of a tax dispute escalating into arrest before the underlying liability is finally determined, while leaving the government's revenue-recovery powers intact.

For the tax administration, it would put greater emphasis on data-driven scrutiny, risk-based investigations and financial recovery rather than arrest as an enforcement tool.

Centre hikes deepwater gas ceiling price to $9.89/MMBtu for 6-months

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, October 4

The government has raised the ceiling price for natural gas produced from difficult fields such as the KG-D6 block of Reliance Industries and BP to $9.89 per million British thermal units (MMBtu) for the six months beginning October 1, from $8.90 previously, while keeping the ceiling for gas produced from the legacy fields of state-run ONGC and Oil India Ltd at $7 per MMBtu.

The new ceiling for gas from deepwater, ultra-deepwater and high-pressure, high-temperature discoveries is applicable for the period October 1, 2026 to March 31, 2027, according to a notification by the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell of the oil ministry.

Gas produced from such difficult areas enjoys marketing and pricing freedom under the government's policy, but is subject to a government-notified ceiling.

The higher ceiling could provide some relief to producers developing India's more technically challenging offshore gas resources, where production costs are generally higher than those from mature onshore and legacy fields.

For gas produced by ONGC and OIL from their nomination fields, the government has notified an APM price of $11.22 per MMBtu for October, but the actual price remains capped at $7 per MMBtu, according to PPAC.

The APM gas price applies to gas produced from the legacy fields of state-owned ONGC and OIL and is used by priority sectors including city gas distribution, fertiliser and power.

For gas produced from new wells of ONGC and OIL in their nomination blocks, the government allows a 10 per cent premium over the prevailing APM gas price, subject to the applicable ceiling. With the APM price for October capped at $7 per MMBtu, the effective price for new-well gas would accordingly be up to $7.70 per MMBtu.

The higher price for new-well gas is aimed at incentivising ONGC and OIL to invest in developing additional reserves and bringing new production on stream, while maintaining the existing ceiling for gas from their older, legacy fields. India follows separate pricing mechanisms for gas from legacy fields of national oil companies and newer discoveries in difficult areas.

In April 2023, the government shifted pricing of gas from legacy fields to a formula linked to 10 per cent of the monthly average crude oil import price, subject to a floor and ceiling. The ceiling was initially fixed at $6.50 per MMBtu and was subsequently raised by $0.25 annually after a two-year freeze.

The APM ceiling was raised to $6.75 per MMBtu from April 2025 and moved to $7 in April this year.

Before the 2023 reform, APM gas prices were revised every six months based on international gas benchmarks and had fluctuated sharply, ranging from $1.79 per MMBtu in 2021 to $8.57 in the six months ended March 2023.

The separate regime for deepwater and other difficult fields was introduced to encourage investment in India's technically challenging hydrocarbon resources by allowing producers greater pricing and marketing flexibility.

Reliance Industries and its partner BP produce gas from the KG-D6 block in the Krishna-Godavari basin, one of India's key deepwater gas-producing areas.

Employers may get ITC on GST for employee insurance cover

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

The GST Council is expected to consider a proposal in its meeting on October 7 to allow employers to claim input tax credit (ITC) on premiums paid for insurance coverage provided to employees.

Under the Goods and Services Tax law, Goods and Services Tax (GST) is exempt on individuals buying life or health policies for themselves or their family.

However, when a business buys life or health cover for its employees, tax is charged on that cover, and until now the business could not claim input tax credit on it.

Currently, an 18 per cent GST is levied on all such group insurance policies.

The GST Council will now consider a proposal to allow businesses to claim credit for buying insurance cover for employees. "This will make insurance cheaper for every employer to provide", sources said.

Almost every organised employer provides cover for its workforce, so the cost of providing the coverage comes down, which should assist the spread of cover and the insurance industry itself, sources added.

India within striking distance of 8% growth on broad-based reforms: Shaktikanta Das

AGENCIES
New Delhi, October 4

Prime Minister's Principal Secretary-2 Shaktikanta Das on Sunday said India is within striking distance of 8 per cent economic growth, driven by broad-based reforms including GST, flexible inflation targeting, banking sector reforms and fiscal prudence.

Speaking at the Kautilya Economic Conclave, former RBI Governor Das said India's resilience amid global uncertainties was the result of broad and mutually reinforcing reforms.

"If the period from July-September 2025-26 to April-June 2026-27 is taken into account, real GDP growth in India just exceeds 8 per cent," he said, adding that this echoed his earlier assessment that India was within striking distance of 8 per cent growth.


Prime Minister's Principal Secretary-2 Shaktikanta Das

India's GDP grew 7.8 per cent in the June quarter, supported by robust domestic demand and favourable investment conditions, Das said.

He said reforms over the past decade were designed to build buffers enabling the economy to absorb disruptions and recover rapidly. These included flexible inflation targeting, GST, fiscal prudence, digital payments and banking reforms.

Das said the financial sector and prudent external-sector management were also key pillars of growth. External indicators remained broadly resilient, supported by export diversification, free trade agreements, a sustained services trade surplus and steady remittances.

Looking ahead, he said India must harness artificial intelligence to sustain high growth, including by developing sovereign AI capabilities through indigenous foundation models, high-performance computing, semiconductor development and innovation.

He also called for deeper financial markets, particularly corporate bonds, pension and insurance funds, municipal finance and infrastructure financing.

Das stressed that strategic self-reliance should not mean isolation and called for sustainable development and climate leadership.

For India to become a developed nation by 2047, sustaining reform momentum would be critical, he said, adding that the goal should be rapid, sustainable and resilient long-term growth.

GST exemption for gold, silver imports likely to go

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, October 4

The GST Council is likely to consider a proposal to withdraw Integrated GST (IGST) exemption on gold, silver and platinum imports by banks and nominated agencies, sources said.

Currently, imports of gold, silver, and platinum are subject to a 3 per cent IGST. However, this tax is exempt when these precious metals are imported by banks and nominated agencies, which are periodically listed by the government.

Sources said that on October 7, the GST Council, comprising Centre and state finance ministers, will consider withdrawing the tax exemption given in 2017 to banks and nominated agencies.

The Goods and Services Tax (GST) exemption on such imports was given in 2017 to facilitate trade that was then tightly canalised, sources said, adding that after withdrawal, bullion exchanges and these agencies will be on the same footing in terms of taxation.

Gold, silver and precious metal imports have been a concern for the government, as they lead to an outflow of foreign currency and dent India's forex reserves. India is the world's second-largest gold consumer after China. Gold imports are mainly driven by the jewellery industry demand.

Held Together by Love: A Reflection on 22nd Annual Convocation of KIIT

A university builds campuses, and it builds people. Buildings stand for a century. People shape centuries that follow

DR. ACHYUTA SAMANTA
Bhubaneswar, October 4

There is one moment at every convocation that I wait for all year. A young graduate walks across the stage, and somewhere in the crowd a mother quietly wipes her eyes. In that moment I see everything we have worked for. Those tears are love, the love of a family that gave everything so that one child could stand there.

From 3 to 5 October 2026, KIIT will hold its 22nd Annual Convocation, and that moment will come again, thousands of times over. Behind every name stands a mother who waited, a father who saved, a teacher who believed.

We began humbly. By the grace and blessings of God, what began so small has grown so vast, and so quickly, that I find it hard to put into words. All of it has come through love. I have held all of this together with one rope, the rope of love, and with nothing else.

Ours is a bond of love. Rules guide us and buildings shelter us, but love alone keeps us together. A bond made of love lives in the mind and the heart of every person it touches, and nobody can break it. I have felt this since my childhood, and I try to live it every single day. Whatever I do, I do out of love. Whatever KIIT has achieved, it has achieved through love.

A university builds two things. It builds campuses, and it builds people. Buildings stand for a century. People shape the centuries that follow. Care sits at the root of all real learning, and students grow best inside relationships where they feel seen.

Education is an act of love, and therefore an act of courage. When young people feel loved, they dare to try. When they dare to try, they learn. Held by that rope of love, our children have grown into remarkable men and women.

Academics remain our first promise, and our infrastructure serves that promise. Classrooms and laboratories, libraries and hostels, the KIMS hospital, sports grounds and green open spaces all exist for one reason. Every young person here should have everything needed to grow into their best self. Research and innovation grow from the same soil. Our faculty and scholars publish widely and hold patents across disciplines, and the KIIT Technology Business Incubator has helped hundreds of young founders turn ideas into ventures.


Dr. Achyuta Samanta

We have embraced artificial intelligence across every discipline, so that our students learn to use it wisely. I want them to master technology without ever letting technology master their hearts.

Love must also carry a young person into a livelihood. This year our students received more than 5,500 job offers from over 700 recruiters. Behind each offer I see a family breathing easier. We have tried to remain student friendly and parent friendly. Through our tutor-mentor system every student has someone to turn to, and I still treasure my simple chats with students on campus. A student at KIIT should never feel alone, and a parent should never feel far away. I consider every child entrusted to us a sacred trust.

KIIT and KISS together serve more than 80,000 students. With our teachers and staff, we are a family of over one lakh people, a township in itself. A university must also serve the land that nurtures it.

Three keystone programmes will add value to everything we do, and all three grow from love. Through Earn While Learn, students work on campus on weekends and earn while they study, gaining confidence along with income. Through the Karmayogi Fellowship, committed young professionals teach, research and live among communities, turning knowledge into service. And from this year, our Kommunity Engagement Programme will take students and faculty to more than 5,000 villages across Odisha with health camps, education, skill-building and awareness. Service, to me, is simply love in action.

CLOSER LOOK

- Our faculty and scholars publish widely and hold patents across disciplines, and the KIIT Technology Business Incubator has helped hundreds of young founders turn ideas into ventures
- KIIT & KISS together serve over 80,000 students. With our teachers & staff, we are a family of over one lakh people, a township in itself. A university must also serve the land that nurtures it

Hundreds and hundreds of professional teachers and experts come to us from every corner of the globe through our Global Faculty Programme and India Trek Programme. Many stays ten days at a time, teaching our students and learning alongside them. Only love brings them here. More than 2,000 international students from over 70 countries study with us, and more than 350 agreements with institutions abroad open doors for young people who once never imagined crossing their own district. Our UN partnerships widen that circle further.

The circle of love has grown wide enough to hold the whole world. A tree that grows fast must grow deep roots, or the first storm will bring it down. In so short a time, in a state like Odisha, an institution of this scale has taken root and flourished. I receive it as a wonder, with humility. Our roots are our values, our people and the love that binds them.

The highlight of this year has been KIIT's rise in status and in the rankings. In the Times Higher Education rankings of 2026, KIIT stands in the 501-600 band across the globe and fifth in India, 169th in Asia and sixth in India, and fourth in India for sustainability impact.

The QS Asia University Rankings 2026 place us first in Odisha, the NIRF India Rankings 2024 placed us 15th among Indian universities, and we hold the NAAC A++ grade. I see these not as trophies but as the world returning our love.

Our students excel on the field as much as in the classroom. We have built one of the largest international-standard sports infrastructures in the country, and KIIT has given India 24 Olympians along with Khel Ratna and Arjuna awardees. This year our athletes brought home five medals from the Commonwealth Games.

A record 54 KIIT and KISS student-athletes are representing India at the 20th Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, and they have already won 21 medals, with the count still rising. Behind each medal lie years of early mornings and coaches who never gave up on them and loved them without condition.

Throughout the year, people from every sector and every walk of life visit our campus. Smt. Nita M. Ambani came to us too, and so do many other distinguished national and international guests. They all come out of love. Each visit gives me real happiness and fresh strength. At this Convocation we also look forward to honouring distinguished men and women whose lives inspire us all.

My dear graduates, you leave with a degree, but I hope you also leave with a way of living. The one secret I can share with you is simple. Love others. Carry competence in one hand and compassion in the other. The world has enough cleverness.

It needs more wisdom joined with love. I thank our faculty and staff, whose untiring efforts have made KIIT so loved by one and all. I thank our students, who return our love and give us our purpose, and our parents, who trust us with their children and with their love.

I thank every well-wisher who has stood by us with love. Whatever KIIT has become, it has become through your love and ours. I remain only a humble servant, holding one end of the rope of love, with folded hands and a grateful heart. Love is the one foundation that never cracks, and KIIT stands on love. Love built KIIT. Love holds it together. Love will carry it forward.

The writer is the Founder of KIIT, KISS and KIMS, Bhubaneswar

Briefs

AIFF polls on Dec 20

KOLKATA: The All India Football Federation (AIFF) on Sunday decided to hold its much-awaited elections on December 20, bringing an end to the uncertainty over the timing of the polls to elect its new office-bearers and executive committee.

The decision was taken at the Special General Body Meeting (SGBM) of the national federation here, which was attended by members of the AIFF Executive Committee, representatives of member associations as well as officials from FIFA and the Asian Football Confederation (AFC).

Alcaraz advances to Tokyo SFs

TOKYO: Top-seeded Carlos Alcaraz advanced to the semifinals of the Japan Open on Sunday, continuing his strong return from a four-month wrist injury layoff.

Alcaraz moved into the final four after his opponent Denis Shapovalov was forced to retire due to a hip injury during their quarterfinal match. The defending champion was leading 7-6 (4), 2-1 after 82 minutes when the Canadian player withdrew. Alcaraz played in the Laver Cup last week, helping Europe claim the trophy with a singles win over Taylor Fritz. Shapovalov had pushed the Spaniard in a grueling opening set, earning a set point at 5-4. Alcaraz defused the threat with a delicate drop shot before taking the set with a commanding tiebreak.

Improvement needed in fielding: Gill

MULLANPUR: India captain Shubman Gill flagged his concerns in the fielding and death bowling department following the team's five wicket loss to West Indies in third and final ODI here on Saturday.

The West Indies' pulled off their highest chase in ODIs by overcoming India's 351/7 in 48.2 overs. In the previous game, India conceded more than 400 runs yet managed to win the game and seal the three-match series.

West Indies captain Shai Hope set up the win with an unbeaten 162 off 143 balls.

AICHI-NAGOYA ASIAN GAMES 2026 CONCLUDES

Dazzling light and musical show brings curtains down

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, October 4

A dazzling light and musical show, sprinkled with a vibrant display of Japan's culture and hospitality, brought the curtains down on the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games as the host country pulled off a spectacular closing ceremony here on Sunday.

After more than two weeks of intense competition, which had produced more than 350 records, including at least 50 world records, the athletes of the 45 countries of Asia joined the festive atmosphere at the Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium to mark the end of the Games marred by logistical troubles and mismanagement in the build-up.

The closing ceremony lasted 90 minutes.

India finished at the fourth place on the medal table with 85 medals (21 gold, 27 silver, 37 bronze), 21 less than the last edition in Hangzhou, China.

China topped the table for the 12th consecutive edition, finishing with 169 gold, 89 silver and 83 bronze for a total of 341 medals, its best haul at an overseas Asian Games. Host Japan ended second with 269 medals (83 gold, 95 silver and 91 bronze), followed by South Korea with 39 gold, 43 silver and 68 bronze.

Olympic Council of Asia President Sheikh Joaan Bin Hamad Al Thani declared the Games closed in the presence of Crown Prince and Crown Princess Akishino. The OCA flag was later handed over to a representative of the organising committee of the 2030 Asian Games in Qatar.

The section relating to OCA flag handover to Doha featured Qatar's Olympic and world champion Mutaz Bashim.

Led by trap shooter Neeru Dhanda, who had won two gold and one silver in the Games, the Indians also joined the festive atmosphere. Around 30 Indian athletes and officials, wearing white and blue kits, took part in the Athletes Parade, waving the tricolour.

To express the closing ceremony's concept of 'One Asia', a hexagonal stage was placed at the centre of the stadium, and it was the highlight of the show. It was adorned with lanterns, a quintessential symbol of Japanese summer, during the grand finale. OCA President Sheikh Joaan Bin Hamad Al Thani said the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games have raised the bar for Asian sport. "I now declared the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games officially closed," Al Thani said.

"Tonight, as we lower the flag on Aichi-Nagoya 2026, we close these Games, but we raise the bar for Asian sport. The flame may be extinguished, but the hopes it has ignited will continue to burn brightly across our continent," he said.

"We have witnessed remarkable comebacks, last-second victories and dramatic near-misses. We have celebrated the rise of new teenage superstars and seasoned champions as they added to their impressive legacies.

"We have seen athletes battle through adversity and injury to claim victory and opponents demonstrate incredible sportsmanship and respect."

He said the Asian Games in Japan will shape the next generation of Asian sport.

"From the first competition to the very last, Asia's finest athletes captivated us with their performances. Over 350 records have been broken, including more than 50 world records. This is a record for our Asian Games."

As per tradition, the OCA chief called upon the youth of Asia to carry this spirit forward and meet again in four years' time for the 21st Asian Games in Doha in 2030.

At the opening ceremony on September 19, the diverse athletes from various Asian countries and regions were represented by multiple layers of rainbow-coloured hearts. For the closing ceremony, the empty space in the centre of the heart was beautifully filled with the emotions and sense of unity.

The idea was to unite the athletes to serve as a catalyst for Asian nations to continue working together in a peaceful environment for many years to come.

At the heart of the performance is the 'bonodori' dance, which originated in Japan and is now popular also in other Asian countries, transcending generations and nationalities. This was showcased in 'Matsuken Samba II', a song that is packed with Nagoya's unique charm and cherished by the Japanese people.



Artists perform during the closing ceremony of Asian Games PTI



Qatar's equestrian athlete Jassim Al Kuwari with the Olympic Council of Asia flag during the closing ceremony of Asian Games, on Sunday PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- The closing ceremony lasted 90 minutes
- India finished at the fourth place on the medal table
- China topped the table for 12th consecutive edition
- The section relating to OCA flag handover to Doha
- The arrival of the dignitaries was followed by a dazzling laser light show



India's flag bearer Neeru Dhanda and others during the closing ceremony PTI

Rest of India outclass J&K to lift Irani Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Sri Nagar, October 4

India pacers Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep shared nine wickets between them as Rest of India swatted aside reigning Ranji Trophy champions Jammu and Kashmir by 167 runs on the fourth day to clinch the Irani Cup here on Sunday.

Chasing 279 runs, Jammu and Kashmir just needed to hang in for a draw to lift the trophy by virtue of their 41-run first innings lead.

But Mukesh (6/33) and Akash (25) ripped J&K's batting unit in a sensational spell to bowl the hosts out for 111.

Openers Shubham Khajuria (32) and Qamran Iqbal (32) shared a 54-run opening wicket stand as the home side looked well-placed for a favourable result. But Akash trapped Iqbal in front of the wicket to snap the alliance.

Mukesh inflicted a double blow on J&K just before lunch, taking out Shubham Pundir and skipper Paras Dogra off successive deliveries in the 15th over.

Punjab FC lose in shootout against Mohun Bagan in IFA Shield

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata, October 4

Punjab FC went down narrowly 3-4 on penalties to defending champions Mohun Bagan Super Giant to end their campaign at IFA Shield here on Sunday.

The Shers stayed competitive throughout 120 minutes and came close to finding the breakthrough on several occasions before Mohun Bagan prevailed in the shootout.

The defending champions will face the winner of the second semi-final between East Bengal FC and NorthEast United FC in the final.

MOHUN BAGAN THREATENED AGAIN FIVE MINUTES LATER WHEN ASISH RAI REACHED AN AERIAL THROUGH BALL

Punjab FC were tested by an intense Mohun Bagan press in the opening stages but remained compact and organised.

The first chance came in the third minute when Lallianzuala Chhangte's effort took a slight deflection, but Arshdeep Singh kept his composure to collect.

Mohun Bagan threatened again five minutes later when Asish Rai reached an aerial through ball and set up Lee Erwin with a first-time pass after Arshdeep rushed off his line.

The Punjab FC defence recovered quickly to block Erwin's effort and clear the danger.

Sabalenka knocked out of China Open

Djokovic outlasts Zverev

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Beijing, October 4

Second-ranked Aryna Sabalenka was bundled out in the third round of the China Open in straight sets by the Czech Republic's Nikola Bartunkova on Sunday.

In the men's draw, Novak Djokovic maintained his perfect record at the tournament with a 4-6, 6-4, 6-4 victory over U.S. Open champion Alexander Zverev in the quarterfinals.

The No. 34-ranked Bartunkova defeated the four-time Grand Slam champion 6-4, 6-3 in just over an hour and a half leaving the tournament without its two top seeds in the first week.

Newly crowned world No. 1 Elena Rybakina was ousted from the tournament on Saturday and will now be joined by Sabalenka in exiting WTA-1000 event in Beijing early.

Sabalenka, who was denied a three-peat at the U.S. Open last month by Rybakina, squandered five break points in the first set as her historic struggles in Beijing continued. The 28-year-old Belorussian has never progressed past the quarterfinals at the event.



"First of all, I focused on myself, to be calm," Bartunkova said. "And Aryna, she's great, she's a legend, she's a Grand Slam champion. So, yeah, I'm really happy that I won the match ... I'm not a girl who celebrates too much."

Djokovic is bidding to win his seventh China Open title and is now 32-0 in Beijing, eclipsing Rafael Nadal's 31-0 start at the French Open for the best start at a tour-level tournament in the Open era.

The Serb started slowly, dropping his serve in the opening game of the match and eventually losing the first set but bounced back to take the next two to secure the win.

"I gave him an early break and then it was hard to come back in the first set," Djokovic said.

Kumkum, Sujeet named first winners of Jaspal Rana, Raja Randhir Singh awards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, October 4

Archer Kumkum Mohod and wrestler Sujeet Kalkal have been named the inaugural recipients of the Jaspal Rana Award and Raja Randhir Singh Award respectively by the Indian Olympic Association for their outstanding performances at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

The awards have been instituted by the IOA to honour the best female and male sportspersons of the Games and commemorate the legacy of two stalwarts of Indian sport who died earlier this year.

Seventeen-year-old Mohod, making her Asian Games debut, won three medals, including two gold, and played a pivotal role in ending South Korea's long-standing dominance in women's recurve archery. IOA president PT Usha hailed Mohod's achievement, saying, "It is fitting that Kumkum is the first recipient of the Jaspal Rana Award, as Jaspal too burst onto the scene as a prodigy at the 1994 Asian Games. Her composure under pressure and her ability to find her best form when her back was to the wall augur extremely well for Indian Archery.

"India's archers have been knocking on the door for more than a decade now, and I firmly believe that this performance by Kumkum and her recurve teammates has shattered the glass ceiling for Indian archery.

"India came close to winning a maiden Olympic medal in the sport at the Paris Olympics, and I am convinced that final frontier will be breached at the Los Angeles Olympics."

KEY POINTS

- The awards have been instituted by the IOA to honour the best female and male sportspersons of the Games
- IOA president PT Usha hailed Sujeet Mohod's achievement

News at a glance



Asian Games 2026 medallist squash player Tanvi Khanna being greeted upon her arrival at IGI Airport, in New Delhi on Sunday PTI

Lamine Yamal scores another early goal in Nations League

OVIEDO: Lamine Yamal kept up his run of early goals in the Nations League when he put Spain ahead with a superb sixth-minute goal in a 3-1 home win against Czechia.

Spain coach Luis de la Fuente shook his head in admiration and disbelief as Yamal cut inside down the right and unleashed a powerful curling shot with his left foot into the top left corner.

Goalkeeper Antonín Kinský could not even get near the ball, and standout Spain midfielder Pedri walked up to hug Yamal as he celebrated near the corner flag.

My eyes are on winning trophy: Vaidehee

NEW DELHI: After missing last year's edition due to injury, two-time former champion Vaidehee Chaudhari is back at the Fenesta Open National Tennis Championship, and has her eyes firmly set on reclaiming the trophy.

Main draw action will begin on Monday at DLTA with Vaidehee leading the women's field along with Shruthi Ahlawat, Sonal Patil and Akanksha Nitture. With the main draw yet to be released, Vaidehee is keeping the focus on herself for now. Defending champion Manish Sureshkumar will lead the men's draw.

India U17 men share spoils with Myanmar in 1st friendly

NEW DELHI: A spirited fightback saw a goal down India U17 men's team restore parity and draw 1-1 with Myanmar in the first friendly match at the StarCity Sports Club in Thanlyin, Myanmar, on Sunday.

The hosts opened the scoreline through Aung Myat Thar in the 42nd minute, before the Blue Colts drew level from Dallalmuon Gangte's penalty in the 73rd minute. After the initial enthusiasm and exuberance displayed by both sets of very eager boys, it was Myanmar who took the lead much against the run of play.

'WILL TAKE EVERY POSSIBLE LEGAL ACTION'

Jr NTR condemned AI-generated explicit video featuring his 'Devara' co-star Janhvi Kapoor



MUMBAI: Telugu superstar Jr NTR on Saturday condemned an AI-generated inappropriate video of his 'Devara: Part 1' co-star Janhvi Kapoor from the film's song 'Chuttamalle', calling the content 'shameful' and vowing legal action against those behind its creation and circulation.

The AI-generated video, which circulated widely on social media before being taken down, digitally manipulates Kapoor's appearance from the song to depict her in a sexually explicit manner.

In a strongly worded post on 'X', Jr NTR called the video 'vile' and 'shameful beyond words'. "In a land that worships women as mothers and goddesses, where 'Matrudevo Bhava' is not just a phrase but a part of our culture, some people have fallen so low that they are using AI to disrespect a woman in the most degrading way possible. Using AI to create something this vile is shameful beyond words," he wrote on 'X'.

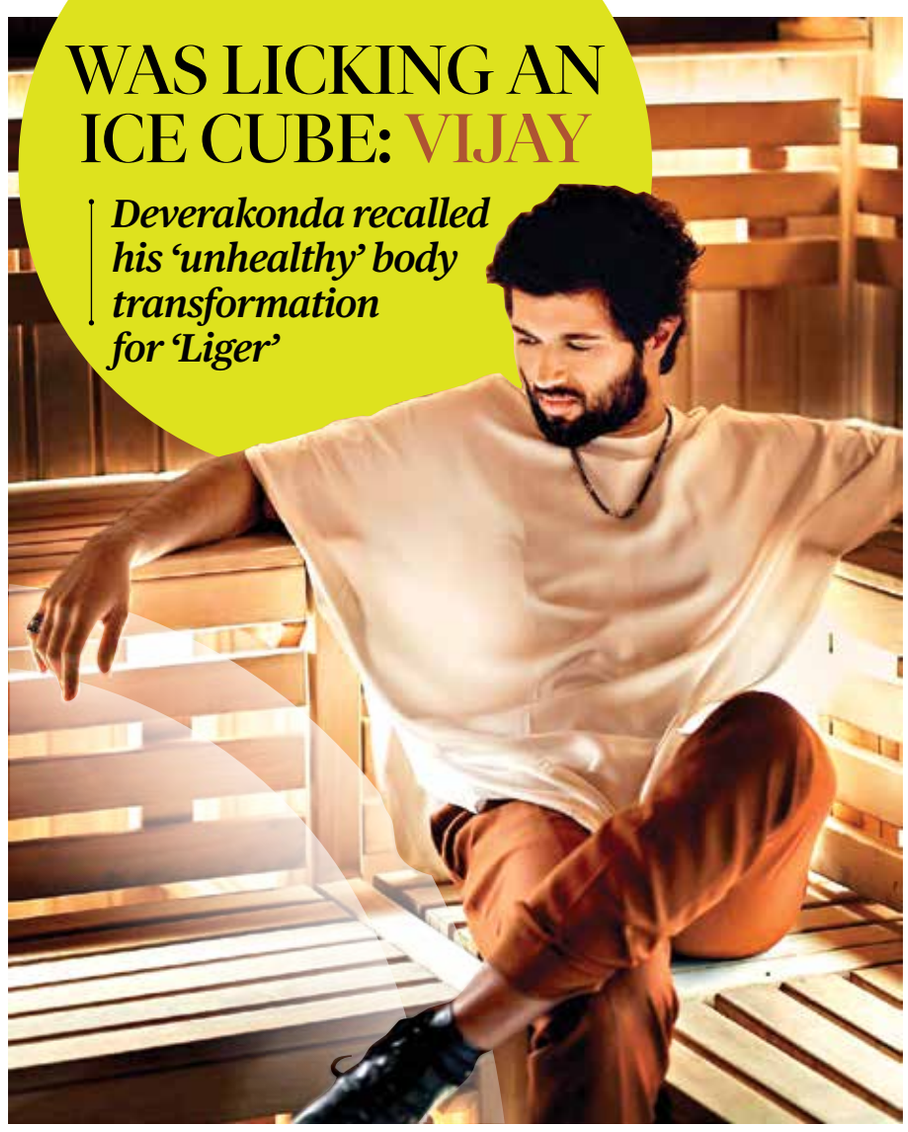
The actor urged people not to watch, share or engage with the video and said he would pursue legal action against those responsible for creating and spreading it. "Please do not watch, share or engage with such content. Today it is someone else. Tomorrow, it could be your mother, sister, wife or daughter. To the scumbags behind this morphed 'Chuttamalle' video, I will not spare any of you. I will take every possible legal action against those who created it and those who are spreading it." PTI

THE VIDEO DIGITALLY MANIPULATED HER APPEARANCE FROM THE SONG TO DEPICT HER IN A SEXUALLY EXPLICIT MANNER



WAS LICKING AN ICE CUBE: VIJAY

Deverakonda recalled his 'unhealthy' body transformation for 'Liger'



Vijay Deverakonda's 2022 film 'Liger' was hyped as his big pan-Indian film, but before one could blink, the film flopped at the box office. That doesn't mean that Vijay didn't put his heart and soul into the film. In a recent interview, he opened up about the massive toll that his body underwent during the preparation of the film, as at one point, he was just taking 200 ml of water. During the shoot, even that wasn't allowed, so he was just licking an ice cube. Vijay admitted that this wasn't healthy and after he was done with the shoot, he was just craving some chilled coconut water.

THE ACTOR SAID THAT THE DEPRIVATION CONSUMED HIM ENTIRELY

He shared that he started with four to six litres of water a day. The intake was gradually reduced and by the end, he was just taking 200 ml of water a day. "In the last 10 hours before the shoot, you're not drinking water. You're just licking an ice cube," Vijay said in a conversation with Sudhir Srinivasan. "It's not at all healthy."

The deprivation consumed him entirely. "Every second, from the time I was drinking 300 ml of water a day, every minute you're just like: water, water, water. That's all you need. That's all you want at that moment," he said. "When I was licking that ice cube and wasn't allowed water, I was sleeping thinking of water. I was like, 'I can't function like this'." He knew he had to endure four more hours of shooting before he could finally drink. His instructions to his team were desperate and precise. "I told them I want coconut water and get four litres of it. I didn't want food." AGENCIES

Tilda Swinton to publish 'MATERIAL EVIDENCE'



LOS ANGELES: Oscar-winning actress Tilda Swinton is set to chronicle her life and career in her first book, 'Material Evidence', which will present her story in an unconventional format inspired by the way memory works. The Scottish star's memoir will be published by Farrar, Straus and Giroux (FSG) in the fall of 2028, the publication house announced on 'Instagram'.

According to the publisher, 'Material Evidence' refuses the structure of a conventional memoir, instead reflecting the associative and sensory nature of memory. "Rather than moving chronologically from childhood to the present, the book proceeds object by object: a christening dress, a letter, a wooden leg, a sweatshirt, a length of embroidery silk and a photograph," said FSG. PTI

THE SCOTTISH STAR'S MEMOIR WILL PRESENT HER STORY IN AN UNCONVENTIONAL FORMAT INSPIRED BY THE WAY MEMORY WORKS



Sony in talks to acquire 'Battlefield' adaptation

The adaptation will be directed by Christopher McQuarrie

LOS ANGELES: Hollywood studio 'Sony Pictures' is in negotiations to acquire the big-screen adaptation of popular video game franchise 'Battlefield', which will be directed by Christopher McQuarrie with Oscar winner Michael B Jordan on board as a producer.

The studio is negotiating for the project following a multi-studio bidding war, reported 'Variety'. 'Sony' declined to comment on the talks.

Jordan, who earlier this year won the Academy Award for Best Actor for 'Sinners', could also star in the film, although his involvement as an actor will depend on several factors.

Additional producers include Electronic Arts' Jesse Stern, Carter Swan of 'Emerald Neon', Roy Lee and Miri Yoon of 'Vertigo' and Elizabeth Raposo, president of Jordan's 'Outlier Society'. PTI

'EVERYONE WAS THRASHING ME'

SALMAN KHAN OPENED UP ABOUT HOW 'DUS KA DUM' SAVED HIM FROM HIS CAREER DOWNFALL



HE ALSO SPOKE ABOUT HOW AMITABH BACHCHAN FOUND A NEW LEVEL OF POPULARITY THROUGH 'KAUN BANEGA CROREPATI'

In the latest 'Weekend Ka Vaar' episode of 'Bigg Boss' Season 20, host Salman Khan recalled how he had almost turned down the 2008 television game show 'Dus Ka Dum' as he was going through a difficult phase at the time. However, his father, writer Salim Khan, advised him to take up the show. Salman also spoke about how Amitabh Bachchan found a new level of popularity through 'Kaun Banega Crorepati' (KBC).

Advising the housemates to be their true selves inside the 'Bigg Boss' house, Salman said, "I want to give you an example from my own life. I did 'Maine Pyaar Kiya' and many other films and then I came on TV after I got a show. And at that time, there was a lot of negativity about me everywhere - from court cases, relationships, to my films."

It was amid this difficult phase that Khan was offered the opportunity to host 'Dus Ka Dum', but the actor admitted that he initially had reservations about taking it up. "I wasn't going to do it because there was so much being talked about against me. Every newspaper and TV channel was thrashing me left, right and centre. I spoke to my father about it and asked for advice."

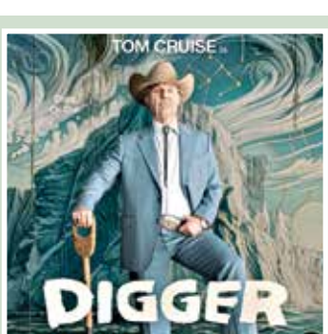
Salman then recalled a piece of advice from his father, Salim Khan, that helped him deal with the negativity, reshape his public image and connect with audiences on a more personal level. "He said, 'Don't you trust your personality, heart and upbringing?' I said yes and he asked me to say yes to the show. He told me to be myself in the show." AGENCIES

Tom Cruise lauds 'DIGGER' despite low box office opening

NEW DELHI: Hollywood star Tom Cruise said he is proud of his recent film 'Digger' despite the film's low opening at the box office. The film, which was released globally, earned only over 3.4 million dollars on opening day at the global box office, emerging as Cruise's lowest first-day grosser.

Cruise shared a series of pictures from the film on his 'Instagram' handle on Saturday and thanked the entire cast and crew. "'Digger' is officially in theatres and I am so honoured to have had the opportunity to create this film alongside such talented artists," he wrote.

THE FILM IS INARRITU'S FIRST ENGLISH-LANGUAGE FILM AFTER THE LEONARDO DICAPRIO-STARRER 'THE REVENANT'



"Thank you to the entire cast and crew for your dedication, hard work and joy. The experience was truly unforgettable and I'm so proud of what we created," he added.

The film is directed by Alejandro Gonzalez Inarritu and serves as the first collaboration of the actor with the Oscar-winning filmmaker. PTI